

Protection and Pricing Power in Sequential Venture Financing

Stephen Dossou*

Mines Paris – PSL

September 17, 2026

Abstract

The accelerator is the only agent that gains from a most-favored-nation clause on its own security. The intermediate investor strictly loses, and neither the seed investor's payoff nor the set of projects financed carries a sign. We establish this in the sequential game Y Combinator's 2022 reform sits in: an accelerator commits on published terms before anything is known, a liquidity shock hits, an intermediate investor covers it and chooses both a price and an amount, and a seed investor funds the residual cost at a priced round. Read against the fixed-equity benchmark, the accelerator earns more at every shock, and most where its tranche converts lowest. The intermediate investor earns less at every shock, including where it advances more and ends up holding more of the company. The seed investor is untouched where that investor merely bridges the shock, and its payoff carries no sign where it pre-funds the round. What settles the case is the interim amount, not the clause: bridging the shock leaves the financing threshold where the benchmark put it, while pre-funding the round carries the clause into it and raises the threshold, so that projects the benchmark financed are not. The clause pushes toward the second, since the tranche is a fixed sum taken out of the block the investor buys. In all three regimes that investor's stake is smaller and the valuation it pays higher—one movement, since the price is the amount divided by the stake—so a high interim valuation appears where fewer projects are financed just as it does where none is lost. The same clause in the intermediate investor's own hands is worth less still: past the second cutoff the round sets the conversion price, and all three payoffs are strictly lower. Which of these cases a population is in is an empirical magnitude, and we estimate it: fitted to the cohorts admitted before the reform, the model puts the median interim amount at a fifth of the round that follows, the exact-funding corner, where the threshold is the benchmark's and the price channel

*Contact: stephen.dossou@minesparis.psl.eu

is silent. What is left is participation—the clause takes from the intermediate investor exactly the capacity it withdraws—and it outweighs the cash the reform adds, by -0.53 against $+0.34$ percentage points of seed graduation, for a net of -0.13 . Seed graduation fell 13.8 points over the same cohorts; delivering that through the clause would take one seventy-four times the size. A best-price clause does not move prices. It rations, by an amount no design on this population can resolve.

JEL Codes: G24, G23, D82, D86

Keywords: Accelerators, Venture Capital, Pre-seed Financing, SAFE, Most-Favored-Nation Clauses, Convertible Securities, Sequential Financing

1 Introduction

Accelerator contracts are not bargained. Y Combinator and Techstars run cohort-based programs of roughly three months that combine early financing with training, mentorship and investor networking, and the terms they offer are uniform across the cohort and imposed on follow-on investors (Zeisberger et al., 2017; Gonzalez-Uribe and Leatherbee, 2018). Until 2022, Y Combinator’s standard deal was \$125,000 for 7% of post-money equity. In January 2022 the accelerator added \$375,000 invested on an *uncapped SAFE with a most-favored-nation provision*: a convertible instrument that automatically adopts the most favourable terms obtained by any other investor between the date of issuance and the next priced equity round.

The clause addresses a problem of sequence. The accelerator commits its capital at admission, before the cohort has produced any information, on terms it publishes in advance and applies uniformly to every company. Investors arriving later choose after observing what each company has become, and they negotiate individually. Nothing prevents such an investor from obtaining a more advantageous basis of calculation than the accelerator’s own—a lower valuation, hence a larger share per dollar advanced—and the accelerator, having already invested and having renounced negotiation, has no instrument with which to respond. This is the commitment asymmetry that McAfee and Schwartz (1994) identify in sequential contracting, and the most-favored-nation clause is the standard remedy: it aligns the accelerator’s conversion terms on whatever the intermediate investor obtains, so that moving first no longer means being treated worst.

Announcing the reform, Y Combinator’s then-president argued that the larger amount would remove the immediate pressure to fundraise on unfavourable terms, encourage more founders to apply, and make it more likely that companies reach a successful seed round.

These are equilibrium claims about a multi-stage financing game, not accounting identities. Between the accelerator and the priced round, a company that runs short

of cash must raise again, and the investor who covers that interim need—we call it the pre-seed investor—sets a price. The MFN clause makes the accelerator’s effective stake a function of that price: the MFN SAFE converts at the lower of the pre-seed valuation and the round valuation. The clause therefore does not merely transfer equity; it changes what the pre-seed investor is solving for. Whether the extra capital improves financing outcomes depends on how that investor responds, and the response is not obvious in either direction.

A natural reading of the clause is that it costs the company nothing: it moves equity between two investors and adds cash, so the firm should be weakly better off. That reading is right on one branch of the model and wrong on the other, and what separates them is not the clause but the size of the amount advanced under it.

Our model has four players and one state variable. An accelerator invests (σ_a, ρ_a) before anything is known; a liquidity shock l then hits; a pre-seed investor may cover the residual need $b = l - \sigma_a$, choosing both how much to advance and at what valuation; the project’s success probability π is revealed; and a seed investor funds whatever remains of the sunk cost I against whatever equity remains.

Five results follow. First, the pre-seed investor’s equilibrium share is independent of the amount it advances: the valuation it sets scales one-for-one with the financing need, so across companies with similar characteristics but different liquidity shocks, pre-seed valuations should co-move with amounts raised while pre-seed ownership stakes should not.

Second, the amount is itself a choice, and a more consequential one than it appears. Cash advanced beyond the shock is not consumed by it; it sits on the balance sheet until the priced round, where it reduces what the seed investor must contribute. Pre-funding therefore buys a lower financing threshold, the trade-off is strictly convex, and the optimal amount is always a corner—either exactly the shock or the whole budget. What keeps the intermediate investor from simply buying the round is not its contract but the size of its balance sheet: with enough budget it pre-empts the seed round altogether, takes the entire residual equity, and the capitalization discipline that made it leave room for a successor disappears. Since an investor that funds the round is the round’s investor rather than an intermediary, we bound its budget by the seed round’s investment cost, which is what the label “pre-seed” asserts about the world and what keeps the seed investor’s residual investment cost strictly positive. Within that bound, advancing exactly the shock—the case a first pass at this environment would write down—is one corner of a genuine choice, and the first result above is a statement about that corner; this paper states the condition under which it is the right one, and gives an observable proxy—the ratio of the interim amount to the round that follows—for deciding which corner the data sit in.

Third, and this is the paper’s central mechanism, the pre-seed investor decides where the MFN SAFE converts, and the amount decides for it. Pricing low keeps the clause inside its own block; pricing high pushes it into the priced round, where the seed

investor must clear it. Both branches are governed by the *same* threshold equation evaluated at two effective investment costs, J and $J + m$, and the two roots order as $\pi_1 < \pi_2$: passing the clause on raises the bar at the round. Two cutoffs in the amount separate three regimes—absorb, price exactly at the round, pass on—and which of them an investor can reach is settled by participation. The comparison that settles it is whether the residual cost it leaves the seed investor lies above or below $J^\dagger$, the point at which pre-funding stops paying. An investor that merely covers the shock is on the far side of that pivot and never leaves the first regime, where the threshold is the benchmark’s: the clause raises the pre-seed valuation by exactly the amount it converts, transfers that equity to the accelerator, and leaves the seed threshold where the benchmark put it. One that pre-funds heavily crosses the pivot and reaches the other two, where the threshold rises to $\widehat{V}_p$ and then to π_2 and financing states are destroyed. The same cash that lowers the bar through J is what opens the regimes that raise it. Ordering the three regimes then adds a fact that belongs to none of them: at a given amount the pre-seed investor’s stake is strictly below its benchmark value in all three, and the valuation at which it invests strictly above—one transfer read twice, since the price is the amount divided by the stake. Measured by the headline valuation, the interim round looks better under the clause in every regime, including those in which financing states are destroyed, so that measure tracks the transfer to the accelerator. What sorts the regimes is the ratio of the pre-seed valuation to the round that follows, together with the probability of reaching that round. The first regime leaves the threshold and the set of projects financed at it where the benchmark put them, and moves the capitalization table underneath: it is there that the intermediate investor gives up more than in either of the other two, since absorbing the clause whole is exactly what leaves the round untouched.

Fourth, and this is where the two margins meet, the clause acts on the amount in a way that carries it toward the pivot. Because the MFN SAFE removes a fixed sum from a block whose size the investor chooses, it dilutes a small amount far more than a large one, strengthens the incentive to pre-fund, and widens the set of budgets at which the investor pre-funds rather than merely bridging. That yields the paper’s one unambiguous prediction about the reform—pre-seed rounds should get larger—but it also drives J down, and J falling below $J^\dagger$ is exactly what opens the regimes in which the threshold moves. The instrument pushes the investor toward the region in which the instrument ceases to be harmless. The same pre-funding lowers the threshold within each regime, so the model does not sign the sum; it identifies the quantity that decides it, the interim amount relative to the round it bridges to.

Fifth, the clause is worth less to an investor who can price. Suppose the intermediate investor takes for itself the protection the accelerator holds against it, converting at the better of its base and the round price—the standard capped SAFE. Its problem then has two regimes rather than three, because above the cutoff the round price no longer depends on the base it names: the cap hands the round the conversion and the investor loses the ability to price at all. The instrument is weakly dominated by

a plain fixed base, and strictly dominated exactly where the clause binds. A most-favored-nation clause protects an investor that cannot reprice and constrains one that can, so its value is a property of the holder rather than of the clause.

Taken together, the five say that the incidence of a contractual protection is decided by the balance sheet of the party it is written against, not by the protection.

The five also settle what the prices in this environment measure, and Section 6.1 collects it. The seed investor prices after π is revealed and still names one valuation for every company it finances, equal to the threshold $\pi_{\min}$ it enforces: the round price is the success probability of the marginal financed project, it rises with the sunk cost the round must clear and with the block converting ahead of it, and the set of companies financed narrows as it rises. The interim price scales with the shock at an unchanged stake, and under the clause it rises by the equity handed to the accelerator. A valuation is therefore a reading of the financing chain that produced it, which is what lets the ratio of the two prices sort the regimes; carried into a comparison of prospects, it reverses the ordering it appears to give.

The question belongs to five literatures that have not met on this margin.

The first is the security-design literature on staged venture financing, which asks which instrument implements the efficient continuation decision when capital arrives in tranches. Gompers (1995) documents staging as the industry’s central control device, and Neher (1999) shows that splitting the investment is what makes the entrepreneur’s promise credible in the first place. Convertible securities are the recurring answer: Cornelli and Yosha (2003) obtain them from the entrepreneur’s incentive to window-dress interim performance ahead of an abandonment option, Schmidt (2003) from double-sided moral hazard, Repullo and Suarez (2004) from a security-design problem over multiple stages, and Casamatta (2003) from the joint provision of capital and advice; the allocation of control that accompanies them is characterized by Hellmann (1998), and the learning-and-stopping structure by Bergemann and Hege (2005). In all of these the instrument is the unknown and the number of investors is two. Here the instrument is given by practice—a post-money SAFE, whose conversion basis is fixed at issuance—and the question is what a clause grafted onto it does once a third party prices an intermediate round.

The second is the literature on robust contracting and the dilution of early claims. Admati and Pfleiderer (1994) show that a fixed-fraction contract—the inside investor holds a constant share across rounds—is the unique contract that makes the insider’s payoff immune to the manipulation of later-round pricing; Corollary 2 below is its SAFE-era counterpart, in an instrument space where the early claim converts at a *price* rather than carrying a fixed share. What the contracts actually contain is documented by Kaplan and Strömberg (2003, 2004) and, for the link between investor characteristics and terms, by Bengtsson and Sensoy (2011), in the tradition of Sahlman (1990). Gornall and Strebulaev (2020) price each class in such a table as a contingent claim on the exit and find the headline post-money standing about half

again above the fair value of the company, the wedge being the protections attached to the most senior round; Section 6.1 works the same separation from the other side, taking the price a round names as an equilibrium object and asking what determines it. That documentation predates the instrument studied here: Coyle and Green (2014) trace the displacement of priced seed rounds by convertible instruments, the contractual shift that made a standardized, non-negotiated pre-priced claim the normal entry point into a company’s capital structure and thereby created the sequencing problem this paper studies.

The third is the industrial-organization literature on most-favored-customer clauses. McAfee and Schwartz (1994) show that nondiscrimination clauses protect the early signatories of a principal who contracts sequentially and cannot resist opportunism towards them, which is precisely the commitment asymmetry here: the accelerator invests before any uncertainty resolves, the pre-seed investor after observing the shock. That literature generally finds such clauses price-rigidifying and anticompetitive (Cooper, 1986; Besanko and Lyon, 1993), because the promise to match any better price removes the incentive to cut it. The sign reverses in this environment for a reason specific to the financing chain: within one regime the clause leaves the financing threshold of the chain untouched, and the party it constrains is not a seller facing rivals but an intermediary choosing where to place a claim it does not hold.

The fourth is the literature on the tiering of early-stage investors. Hellmann and Thiele (2015) study the equilibrium interaction between angel and venture capital markets, where a downstream tier holds up an upstream one—structurally the closest financing game to the sequence studied here, with the difference that their instruments are given whereas the instrument is the object of study in this paper. That tiers differ in what they bring, and that the difference is priced, is established by Hellmann and Puri (2002) and Hochberg et al. (2007); accelerators specifically are evaluated by Gonzalez-Uribe and Leatherbee (2018) and Hallen et al. (2020), who find effects on venture development but treat the program’s terms as fixed. Two features of the environment make those terms worth modelling now: the collapse in the cost of starting a company has compressed the interval between the accelerator and the priced round (Ewens et al., 2018), and the risk that a company fails to raise its next round is a first-order determinant of early-stage financing (Nanda and Rhodes-Kropf, 2017; Lerner and Nanda, 2020). It is exactly that risk—the probability that the seed round does not happen—that the clause displaces between the parties.

The fifth is the literature on credit rationing, in which a price is a screening device rather than a market-clearing one. Stiglitz and Weiss (1981) show that a lender raising its rate worsens the pool it attracts, so the rate settles below the level that would clear the market and borrowers are rationed in equilibrium; price and quantity are determined together, an argument Jaffee and Russell (1976) had opened on the same margin, and De Meza and Webb (1987) show that carrying it from debt to equity changes the direction of the distortion rather than removing it. The seed valuation of Proposition 1 plays that role in a chain of equity claims: it is the threshold $\pi_{\min}$ the round enforces, and the projects below it go unfinanced. What sets the bar here is a

capitalization table rather than a pool. The investor doing the rationing observes π before it prices, so what its threshold registers is the block of claims converting ahead of it together with the sunk cost it must still clear—and each of those is the residue of a financing decision taken earlier in the sequence. Rationing in this environment is a property of the claims a company has already issued, which is what puts it within reach of the clause of Section 4.

The theory ends without a verdict on the reform, and deliberately: the sum of its channels is signed by how much intermediate investors pre-fund relative to the round they bridge to, which is a magnitude and not a modelling choice. The second half of the paper supplies it. We estimate the model by simulated method of moments on the 962 Y Combinator companies admitted before January 2022, on eleven moments covering participation at both stages, the size of interim rounds and the size of the priced rounds that follow them. The specification the model actually writes—one in which what the entrepreneur must be left to run the company is part of what the seed round finances—is not rejected, and the restriction setting that component to zero is rejected decisively.

The estimates locate the corner. The median interim amount is a fifth of the round that follows it, which is exact funding: intermediate investors cover the shock and do not pre-fund, so no participating investor reaches the first cutoff and the adverse threshold regimes are empty. The price channel is therefore silent in every bootstrap draw, and what remains is the participation cap, which the clause lowers by exactly the sum it converts. Running the reform through the fitted equilibrium gives +0.34 percentage points of seed graduation from the cash against -0.53 from the clause, for a net of -0.13 . Two magnitudes need no calibration of the exit scale to read: the mass of interim rounds smaller than the accelerator’s additional cash is 3.1%, which caps at under a point what the cash channel can remove from a bridge rate that fell 19.5; and reproducing the observed 13.8-point fall in graduation through the clause would require it to be 73.7 times its actual size. The reform is not the size of the thing that moved.

That has a consequence for how the question can be asked at all, and it is why the empirical half is a calibration rather than a research design. We also ran the natural difference-in-differences against an accelerator that changed nothing, and it fails its own pre-trend tests decisively—the graduation gap declines continuously from 2020 and half the total fall occurs inside the control period, a year before the clause existed. The estimates explain that failure instead of apologising for it. An estimand of a tenth of a point is two orders of magnitude below what two thousand companies resolve, so the design was not underpowered by accident and more cohorts would not help. Where the reform is visible is on the amount of the round it precedes.

The rest of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 lays out the environment—agents, valuations, and the timing of the three financing decisions. Section 3 solves a contract without the clause by backward induction and establishes the benchmark against which it is measured: the independence of the pre-seed share from the amount

advanced, the pre-funding problem that decides the amount, and the partition of liquidity shocks into no-round, pre-seed and liquidation regions. Section 4 adds the MFN SAFE, separating its cash channel from its MFN channel, solving the pricing problem into three conversion regimes, showing which of them participation leaves reachable, and deriving what the clause does to the amount. Section 5 estimates the model on the 962 companies admitted before the reform, locates the corner, and runs the reform through the fitted equilibrium. Section 6 collects what the equilibrium prices measure, draws the empirical implications, and returns to the claims made for Y Combinator’s 2022 reform. Section 7 concludes. Proofs are collected in Appendix A, and Appendix B asks what displacement of the primitives reproduces the post-reform period.

2 Model

2.1 Agents

Suppose there is no time preference and all the agents below are risk-neutral and profit-maximizing.

Let’s introduce entrepreneurs without initial budget. Each entrepreneur carries a project requiring a two-stage financing path: surviving an interim liquidity shock $l \in (0, 1)$ and clearing a sunk cost I at a priced seed round. Each project yields a stochastic outcome in $\{0, 1\}$. 0 means failure and 1 means success. Without l , the project cannot reach the seed round. Without I at the seed round, the project cannot succeed. A project is characterized by its probability of success $\pi \in [0, 1]$. Note that the probability of success is equal to the expected outcome. Each entrepreneur knows the expected outcome of his project. Let f be the probability density function of π , F denote its cumulative distribution function, g be the probability density function of l , G denote its cumulative distribution function.

Monopolistic accelerators and pre-seed investors are sponsors for entrepreneurs to help them survive the interim liquidity shock until the revelation of their projects’ expected outcome and the seed stage. Accelerators invest ex-ante liquidity shock. Pre-seed investors invest ex-post liquidity shock.

Once the round has closed, the entrepreneur runs the project, at a private cost $c_E > 0$ he bears himself and that no contract transfers. The outcome is realised only if he runs it, and he runs it only if what he still holds covers that cost: writing ρ_E for his share, the project is run when $\rho_E \pi \geq c_E$. This is the one participation constraint of the environment that cannot be normalised away. Refusing a round leaves the entrepreneur with a company that cannot reach the next one, so his outside option *before* each round is zero; after the round it is not, because the alternative to running the project is not running it.

The priced round must therefore cover both, and we let I denote what it covers: the investment the project requires, and the cost the entrepreneur must be left to run it. The seed investor advances the first and prices the second, so it puts in $I - c_E$ and the round is worth I to the company. Everything below is written in I , so no result carries c_E explicitly; what c_E changes is who ends up holding the company, and Proposition 1 is where that is read.

2.2 Allocations and valuations

When seed investors allocate σ_s to a project, it is with the promise that when payoffs are realized, they will take a *share* ρ_s of the realized outcome of the project. The *post-money valuation* V of a project corresponds to the ratio of the amount invested σ_s by the share ρ_s at the seed stage. The *pre-money valuation* is $V - \sigma_s$.

Without knowing either π or l but their respective distributions, the accelerator invests σ_a in exchange of a share ρ_a . After the liquidity shock l , the pre-seed investor invests σ_p in exchange of a share ρ_p . The share ρ_p can be fixed at the time of pre-seed investment or can be conditioned on the seed stage.

2.3 Definitions and assumptions

A project's *initial net present value* is defined as the difference of its expected outcome and the sum of the expected liquidity shock and the investment cost. For notational simplicity, the *initial market net present value*, which corresponds to the initial outside option's net present value, is taken to be 0.

(A1): $\mathbb{E}(\pi - l) - I > 0$ and f is log-concave

The first part of (A1) means that the average project is worth financing. This assumption can be thought of as conditioned on an accelerator preselection process supposed here independent from the game. The second part—that $\log f$ is concave—is a standard regularity condition satisfied by the uniform, normal, logistic, and exponential distributions, among others. It implies that the hazard rate $f/(1 - F)$ is increasing.

Cash is fungible across dates. An amount advanced at the interim stage and not consumed by the shock stays on the balance sheet and is still there at the priced round, where it reduces the sum the seed investor must contribute. Nothing in the environment forces the pre-seed investor to advance exactly what the shock requires, and Section 3.3 shows that what bounds its amount is not the accounting but its own capacity.

Assumption 1 (B). The pre-seed investor can advance at most β , with

$$\beta \leq I.$$

The accelerator's amount and the seed investor's contribution are unconstrained.

Two features of (B) matter, and both are descriptive rather than technical.

The constraint falls on the intermediate investor alone. Pre-seed vehicles are small relative to the rounds they precede, while the seed investor moves last, knows π , and is the marginal supplier of capital to a project whose value is by then established. The accelerator's budget is left free because its amount is a design object rather than a constraint.

The bound is the seed round's own investment cost. A pre-seed amount is measured in hundreds of thousands and the round that follows it in millions, so an intermediate investor able to fund I on its own is not an intermediate investor: it is the round. The seed round always happens, and the pre-seed investor always has a successor to accommodate. This is what makes the pricing problem of Sections 3–4 non-degenerate, and Remark 1 follows the argument to the corner a larger balance sheet would reach.

2.4 Timing

The game structure is as follows. First, without knowing either π or l but their respective distributions, the accelerator proposes (ρ_a, σ_a) to the entrepreneur. Then a liquidity shock occurs and the pre-seed investor proposes (ρ_p, σ_p) , choosing an amount $\sigma_p \leq \beta$ that must at least cover the shock, and a valuation at which its claim converts. Whatever it advances beyond the shock stays in the firm. Finally, a market shock reveals π and enables a seed round proposal of $(\sigma_s, \rho_s) = (J, \frac{J}{V})$, where J is the part of the investment cost the firm has not already carried over.

The entrepreneur's outside option is normalized to zero at each stage.

Each claimant holds a share of the outcome of the projects that reach the round, net of what it advanced. Writing V^* for the equilibrium threshold and using $\pi_{\min}^* = V^*$,

$$\begin{aligned}\Pi_a &= \rho_a^* M(V^*) - \sigma_a^*, & \Pi_p &= \rho_p^* M(V^*) - \sigma_p^*, \\ \Pi_s &= (J - c_E) S(V^*), & \Pi_E &= c_E S(V^*),\end{aligned}\tag{1}$$

where $S(V) := M(V)/V - (1 - F(V))$, the last two taking that form because each contributes at the round and is paid in the states where it occurs: the seed investor advances $J - c_E$ for $(J - c_E)/V^*$ of the company, and the entrepreneur runs the project at cost c_E for c_E/V^* of it. The accelerator and the pre-seed investor advance before π is revealed, so their amounts are sunk; the other two are not.

Table 1 collects the notation. The primitives are the two shocks and the investment cost; everything else is either a contract—an amount and the share it buys—or an object the equilibrium generates.

Panel A. Primitives and contracts

π, f, F	Project's probability of success, its density and cdf
l, g, G	Interim liquidity shock, its density and cdf
I	Cost the priced round must cover: the project's investment and the cost the entrepreneur must be left to run it
c_E, ρ_E	That cost, and the share it leaves him, $\rho_E^* = c_E/\pi_{\min}$ (Proposition 1)
β	Pre-seed investor's budget, $\beta \leq I$ (Assumption 1)
(σ_a, ρ_a)	Accelerator's amount and share in the benchmark
(ρ_a^0, m)	Headline share, and the amount the accelerator places in an uncapped SAFE carrying an MFN clause, under the reform (Section 4)
(σ_p, ρ_p, V_p)	Pre-seed amount, share, and the price its claim converts at
(σ_s, ρ_s, V)	Seed amount, share, and post-money price of the round
$b = I - \sigma_a$	Residual need the accelerator's amount leaves
$\Delta = \sigma_p - b$	Cash advanced beyond the shock and still in the firm at the round
$J = I - \Delta$	Seed investor's residual investment cost, (2)

Panel B. Objects the equilibrium generates

$M(x)$	$M(x) = \int_x^1 \pi f(\pi) d\pi$, the expected outcome contributed by projects above x ; governs every participation decision
k	Equity base left to the investors arriving after the accelerator: $1 - \rho_a$ in Section 3, $1 - \rho_a^0$ from Section 4 on
$\pi_{\min}, \pi(J)$	Seed financing threshold, and the threshold map in the benchmark (Corollary 1)
$\varphi_J, W(J)$	Value of the convertible claim as a function of the threshold it engineers, and that value at its optimum, (3)
$\Lambda(J)$	$\Lambda(J) = M(\pi(J))/\pi(J)$, the marginal value of pre-funding a dollar of the round (Lemma 3)
$\bar{\sigma}_p$	Amount cutoff separating exact funding from pre-funding (Proposition 3)
$\bar{x}, J^\dagger$	Pivot solving $M(\bar{x}) = \bar{x}$, and the residual cost at which $\pi(J^\dagger) = \bar{x}$, where Λ crosses one
$\bar{\sigma}_p, \bar{b}$	Participation caps on the amount and on the shock (Propositions 4 and 7)
ψ, D	$\psi = k\pi^3 f/D$, $D = \pi^2 f + M$; the threshold equation is $J = \psi(\pi)$, so $\pi(\cdot) = \psi^{-1}$ (Lemma 2)
$\Phi(\pi; J)$	Threshold equation both regimes collapse onto, $\Phi = D(\psi - J)$ (Definition 1)
π_1, π_2	Its roots at J and at $J + m$: the seed threshold when the clause converts in the pre-seed block, and when it converts into the round
$\hat{V}_p$	Price at which the MFN SAFE is indifferent between converting at the pre-seed price and at the round price (Lemma 4)
T_1, T_2	Amounts at which the investor stops absorbing the clause and starts passing it to the round, (7)
$\bar{\sigma}_p^m$	Largest amount a participating investor advances under the clause (Proposition 10)
l_0, l_1, l_2	Shocks at which the figures cross a regime boundary: $l_0 = \sigma_a + m$, and $\sigma_p = T_1$, $\sigma_p = T_2$
Π_a, Π_p, Π_s	Expected payoffs of the accelerator, the pre-seed investor and the seed investor, (1)
S	$S(V) = M(V)/V - (1 - F(V))$, the seed investor's payoff per unit of residual investment cost; strictly decreasing (Proposition 18)

Table 1: Notation. Panel A lists what is given before any decision is taken, together with the three contracts; Panel B lists the objects constructed from them, with the result that defines each. The only quantities carrying a decision are (σ_a, ρ_a) , (σ_p, V_p) and the seed price V ; Δ , J and b are accounting identities that follow from them.

3 Benchmark: fixed-equity SAFE

Before proceeding, it is useful to establish a benchmark result, namely that when the accelerator’s contract is independent from the pre-seed and seed rounds, raising the amount invested increases seed success and the probability that no pre-seed round is needed. We solve by backward induction.

3.1 Seed stage

The seed investor moves last, knows π , and faces the capitalization table (ρ_a, ρ_p) . It does not necessarily have to fund the whole of I : writing $\Delta \geq 0$ for the cash the pre-seed investor advanced beyond the shock and that the firm still holds, the seed investor’s *residual investment cost* is

$$J := I - \Delta \in (0, I], \quad (2)$$

strictly positive because Assumption (B) caps the pre-seed investor’s amount at I , so that covering the shock leaves it strictly less than I to park. It solves

$$\max_V \int \left(\frac{J}{V(\pi)} \pi - J \right) f(\pi) d\pi$$

under two constraints: the capitalization table, $\rho_a + \rho_p + \rho_E + \frac{J - c_E}{V} \leq 1$, and the entrepreneur’s, $\rho_E \pi \geq c_E$ at every project it finances. It names one valuation for all of them, so the second binds at the weakest project financed.

Write $\pi_{\min}$ for the lowest probability of success the seed investor is willing to finance.

Proposition 1. *The seed investor proposes the valuation $V = \frac{J}{1 - \rho_a - \rho_p}$ and finances exactly the projects above $\pi_{\min} = V$. The round leaves the entrepreneur $\rho_E^* = c_E / \pi_{\min}$ and the seed investor $\rho_s^* = (J - c_E) / \pi_{\min}$, so that $\rho_a + \rho_p + \rho_s^* + \rho_E^* = 1$.*

Some worth financing projects don’t reach the seed stage. Two features of $\pi_{\min}$ drive everything below. It rises with the block of claims converting ahead of it, $\rho_a + \rho_p$ —the familiar crowding channel—and it falls, one for one in the numerator, with any cash the firm brings to the round. The pre-seed investor controls both: the first through its price, the second through its amount.

The table the round leaves is worth reading on its own. The three investors do not exhaust the company: what the entrepreneur keeps, $c_E / \pi_{\min}$, is the price of having the project run, and it is the share of a claimant no round can price out. The seed investor’s own stake is $(J - c_E) / \pi_{\min}$ rather than the whole of what the table leaves, so the fraction of the company a priced round buys falls short of $1 - \rho_a - \rho_p$ by exactly that amount. A round that is large relative to the cost of running the project buys

most of what is left; one that is small buys little of it, and the ratio of the two is $1 - c_E/J$.

3.2 Pre-seed stage

The pre-seed investor moves at $t = 4$, after the liquidity shock l has been realised but before π is revealed. It must cover the residual need $b := l - \sigma_a$, chooses the amount $\sigma_p \leq \beta$ it advances, and chooses the valuation V_p at which its claim converts—or declines to participate. Its share is $\rho_p = \sigma_p/V_p$, so choosing V_p is equivalent to choosing ρ_p .

Throughout, write

$$M(x) := \int_x^1 \pi f(\pi) d\pi, \quad \text{so that} \quad M'(x) = -xf(x).$$

$M(x)$ is the expected outcome contributed by projects above x ; it is the object that governs every participation decision below.

The two halves of the pre-seed investor's decision—how much to advance, and at what price—separate cleanly, and only one of them is settled here.

Lemma 1. *Conditional on proposing, the pre-seed investor advances at least the residual need: $\sigma_p \geq b = l - \sigma_a$.*

Under-funding is dominated because it buys nothing: the shock is left uncovered, the firm is liquidated before π is revealed, the claim never converts, and the amount is sunk.

Over-funding is a different matter. An amount larger than the shock leaves $\Delta = \sigma_p - b$ on the balance sheet, and by Proposition 1 the seed investor's residual investment cost falls to $J = I - \Delta$. Fix Δ and carry $J = I - \Delta$ through the algebra. The pre-seed investor is repaid only on projects that reach and clear the seed round, that is on $\{\pi \geq \pi_{\min}\}$, and loses its outlay otherwise:

$$\max_{V_p} \int_{\pi_{\min}}^1 \left(\frac{\sigma_p}{V_p} \pi - \sigma_p \right) f(\pi) d\pi - \int_0^{\pi_{\min}} \sigma_p f(\pi) d\pi = \max_{V_p} \underbrace{\sigma_p \left(\frac{M(\pi_{\min}(V_p))}{V_p} - 1 \right)}_{=: \Pi_p(V_p)}.$$

Proposition 2. *At a given amount, the pre-seed investor proposes the valuation V_p^* satisfying*

$$\sigma_p f(\pi_{\min}) \pi_{\min}^3 = J V_p M(\pi_{\min}).$$

Write $\pi(J)$ for the threshold the pre-seed investor's optimal price engineers, as a function of the residual investment cost it leaves.

Corollary 1. *At a given amount, $\pi(J)$ solves*

$$(1 - \rho_a) f(\pi) \pi^3 = J \left(M(\pi) + f(\pi) \pi^2 \right),$$

an equation in which σ_p does not appear.

Consequently the equilibrium pre-seed share $\rho_p^* = 1 - \rho_a - J/\pi(J)$, the threshold $\pi(J)$, and the conditional seed probability $1 - F(\pi(J))$ depend on the amount only through the pre-funded part Δ , and not through the residual need b . In particular, if the amount covers exactly the shock ($\Delta = 0$, $J = I$), all three are independent of b and the valuation V_p^* scales one-for-one with b .

The economics is transparent: the monopolist pre-seed investor prices so as to hold a target share of the company—the share that optimally trades off its stake against the seed investor’s financing constraint—and the valuation is merely the instrument through which any cash amount is converted into that share. The qualification matters, and it is what the next subsection exploits. Cash advanced to *cover* the shock is invisible to the threshold; cash advanced *beyond* it is not, because it changes J .

3.3 Pre-funding the seed round

Two objects recur from here to the end of the paper. Write k for the equity base the capitalization table leaves to the investors arriving after the accelerator—so $k := 1 - \rho_a$ in this section, and $k := 1 - \rho_a^0$ from Section 4 on, where the accelerator holds a headline share plus an MFN SAFE—and let

$$\varphi_J(\pi) := \left(k - \frac{J}{\pi} \right) M(\pi), \quad W(J) := \max_{\pi} \varphi_J(\pi) = \varphi_J(\pi(J)) \quad (3)$$

be the expected value of the convertible claim as a function of the threshold it engineers, and that value at its optimum. The two are tied to the first-order condition already in hand: differentiating (3) and using $M'(\pi) = -\pi f(\pi)$ gives

$$\varphi'_J(\pi) = - \frac{k \pi^3 f(\pi) - J(\pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi))}{\pi^2},$$

so the threshold equation of Corollary 1 is exactly the first-order condition of that maximization—and, by Lemma 2 below, $\pi(J)$ is its maximizer rather than merely a critical point. Both objects therefore inherit whatever base the section they are read in supplies; only k changes when the accelerator’s contract does. The pre-seed investor’s maximized payoff at a given amount is then

$$\Pi_p = W(J) - \sigma_p. \quad (4)$$

It captures the whole claim it has engineered and pays for it with the amount it advances. Writing that amount as $\sigma_p = b + \Delta$ and the residual investment cost it

leaves the seed investor as $J = I - \Delta$, the pre-seed investor's remaining problem—having already priced optimally—is

$$\max_{\Delta \in [0, \beta - b]} \Pi_p(\Delta) = W(I - \Delta) - b - \Delta, \quad (5)$$

the range coming from Assumption (B) net of what the shock already required (Lemma 1): covering the shock is prior, and pre-funding is a decision about the residual budget $\beta - b$ alone. An investor with $\beta < b$ has no such decision to make—it does not participate.

The threshold map $\pi(\cdot)$ and the value W are built from a single ratio. Write

$$D(\pi) := \pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi), \quad \psi(\pi) := \frac{k \pi^3 f(\pi)}{D(\pi)}, \quad \pi \in (0, 1), \quad (6)$$

so that two identities hold by inspection: the threshold equation of Corollary 1 reads $J = \psi(\pi)$, and the derivative computed after (3) is $\varphi'_J(\pi) = -D(\pi)(\psi(\pi) - J)/\pi^2$. The notation $\pi(J)$ presumes three further things: that the equation has a unique solution, that this solution maximizes φ_J , and that it rises with J . All three follow from a single property of ψ .

Lemma 2 (The threshold map). *Under (A1), ψ is a strictly increasing bijection from $(0, 1)$ onto $(0, k)$, and $\psi(\pi) < k\pi$. Hence, for every $J \in (0, k)$:*

- (i) *the threshold equation has a unique solution $\pi(J) = \psi^{-1}(J)$, and $\pi(J) > J/k$;*
- (ii) *$\pi(J)$ maximizes φ_J , which strictly increases below it and strictly decreases above it, so $W(J) = \varphi_J(\pi(J))$;*
- (iii) *$\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing.*

Write $\Lambda(J) := M(\pi(J))/\pi(J)$ for the value of one point of equity at the threshold the claim engineers, divided by the price at which that point is bought.

Lemma 3 (Convexity). *$W'(J) = -\Lambda(J)$, and under (A1) Λ is strictly decreasing, so*

$$\Pi'_p(\Delta) = \Lambda(I - \Delta) - 1$$

is strictly increasing in Δ : the objective in (5) is strictly convex.

The interpretation is direct. Recall that the seed investor prices at $V = \pi_{\min}$ (Proposition 1), so it takes $J/\pi_{\min}$ of the company to fund J : one unit of investment cost lifted off its plate frees $1/\pi_{\min}$ points of equity for the pre-seed investor, and each point is worth $M(\pi_{\min})$. At the equilibrium threshold $\pi_{\min} = \pi(J)$, pre-funding one unit therefore returns $M(\pi(J))/\pi(J) = \Lambda(J)$ and costs exactly one. Now pre-funding lowers that threshold: $\pi(J)$ is strictly increasing in J , since a seed investor with less to contribute needs less equity to break even and will fund weaker projects—this is

Lemma 2, and it holds after the pre-seed investor has re-optimized its price. Convexity follows because both factors of the return move the same way as the threshold falls: $1/\pi(J)$ rises, since at a lower price the seed investor takes more equity per unit it contributes, so removing one unit frees more of it; and $M(\pi(J))$ rises, since more projects survive to convert, so each point freed is worth more. The next unit advanced is worth strictly more than the last. This settles the shape of the answer before its location—a convex objective on an interval is maximized at an endpoint, so $\sigma_p^* \in \{b, \beta\}$ regardless of parameters. What remains is to say which.

Write $\tilde{\sigma}_p = b + \tilde{\Delta}$ for the amount at which the two candidates of (5) are worth the same.

Proposition 3 (A single threshold). *The pivot $\tilde{\sigma}_p$ exists, is unique in $[b, b + I]$, and for every budget β admissible under (B),*

$$\sigma_p^* = \begin{cases} b & \text{if } \beta \leq \tilde{\sigma}_p, \\ \beta & \text{if } \beta > \tilde{\sigma}_p. \end{cases}$$

Moreover $\tilde{\Delta} \geq 0$ is the same number for every residual need b .

Covering the shock therefore shifts the whole schedule, leaving unchanged how much pre-funding beyond it is worth doing.

The appendix constructs $\tilde{\Delta}$ from two objects reused in Section 4: the pivot $\bar{x}$, the unique solution of $M(\bar{x}) = \bar{x}$, and the residual investment cost $J^\dagger$ at which $\pi(J^\dagger) = \bar{x}$ —where Λ crosses one. These locate the minimizer of Π_p at $\Delta^\dagger := I - J^\dagger$; the payoff falls to that point and rises past it, leaving the two endpoints of $[0, \beta - b]$ as the only candidates, and the comparison between them is monotonic in β .

Two consequences carry into the rest of the paper. First, on the pre-funding branch the seed investor’s residual investment cost is $J = I - \beta + b$, so the financing threshold $\pi(J)$ is strictly increasing in the shock b and strictly decreasing in the budget β : a deeper pocket upstream lowers the bar at the priced round, a larger interim shock raises it. On the other branch it is $\pi(I)$, constant in both. This is the comparative static the cash channel of Section 4 runs on. Second, Assumption (B) keeps $J > 0$ on either branch, so the seed round occurs in every financed state. Pre-funding acts on the seed constraint alone: reaching the priced round still requires the shock to have been absorbed, and no amount can buy its way past that—the liquidity constraint is what its first b units are for.

Remark 1 (Why a monopolist leaves room). A monopolist pre-seed investor leaves room because it needs a successor: every point of share it takes is a point the seed investor cannot have, and that investor will not fund J out of a stub worth less than J . Pre-funding erodes that discipline, and (B) bounds the erosion. Relax the bound to $\beta \geq b + I$ and the argument runs to its corner—the investor advances $b + I$, the residual investment cost and the threshold fall to zero, and it holds the entire residual

equity $1 - \rho_a$ for a payoff $(1 - \rho_a)\mathbb{E}(\pi) - b - I$ (appendix). It then prices against no one, which makes it a different institution: an investor that funds the round is the round's investor. What keeps an intermediary intermediate is the size of its balance sheet rather than the terms of its contract.

3.4 Which firms need a pre-seed round

Proposition 3 leaves the pre-seed investor in one of two regimes, and both are worth writing down. Call the investor *constrained* when $\beta \leq \bar{\sigma}_p$, so that it advances the shock and no more— $\sigma_p = b$, $\Delta = 0$, $J = I$ —and *pre-funding* when $\beta > \bar{\sigma}_p$, so that it advances its whole budget and $\sigma_p = \beta$, $J(b) = I - \beta + b$. The partition of shocks differs between them in exactly one respect: whether the financing threshold is constant across the region where a pre-seed round occurs. We take the constrained case first, writing $\pi_{\min}^* := \pi(I)$ for the threshold it delivers.

Write

$$\bar{\sigma}_p := M(\pi_{\min}^*) \rho_p^* = M(\pi_{\min}^*) \left(1 - \rho_a - \frac{I}{\pi_{\min}^*} \right)$$

for the expected value of the claim the pre-seed investor engineers at its optimal price.

Proposition 4. *The pre-seed investor participates if and only if $\sigma_p = l - \sigma_a \leq \bar{\sigma}_p$.*

The cap is $\bar{\sigma}_p = W(I)$: by (4) the most cash the pre-seed investor can sink is the expected value of the claim it engineers. There is therefore a maximum liquidity shock, determined entirely by (ρ_a, I, F) , beyond which no pre-seed financing occurs at any price. Beyond it no valuation works—lowering V_p to grab a larger share raises $\pi_{\min}$ and destroys the very conversion states the share pays in.

Write $\pi_0 := I/(1 - \rho_a)$ for the threshold a firm faces when it reaches the seed round without a pre-seed investor on its cap table.

Proposition 5. *The realisation of l sorts every firm into one of three regimes:*

- (N) No pre-seed round, $l \leq \sigma_a$: here $(\rho_p, \sigma_p) = (0, 0)$, the seed investor finances the projects $\pi \geq \pi_0$, and the conditional seed probability is $1 - F(\pi_0)$.
- (P) Pre-seed round, $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$: here $\rho_p = 1 - \rho_a - I/\pi_{\min}^*$, the seed investor finances the projects $\pi \geq \pi_{\min}^*$, and the conditional seed probability is $1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)$.
- (L) Liquidation, $l > \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$: the shock exceeds what any investor will advance, the firm is liquidated at zero before the seed stage, and the conditional seed probability is 0.

Moreover $\pi_0 < \pi_{\min}^*$.

The ordering is the price of survival: a pre-seed round costs equity, and the dilution it costs raises the bar at the seed round.

The two boundaries have different natures, which matters for the policy analysis below. The lower boundary σ_a is *mechanical*—a cash amount chosen before anything is known, moved one for one by the accelerator’s amount. The upper boundary $\sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$ is *endogenous*— $\bar{\sigma}_p$ is an equilibrium object, built from $\pi_{\min}^*$ and ρ_p^* , and it therefore moves with anything that shifts the pre-seed investor’s problem, including the MFN SAFE of Section 4.

Proposition 6. *The unconditional probability of seed success is*

$$\mathbb{P}(\text{seed}) = G(\sigma_a)(1 - F(\pi_0)) + (G(\sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p) - G(\sigma_a))(1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)).$$

The pre-funding regime keeps this architecture and changes one thing: the threshold now moves with the shock across the region where a round occurs.

Suppose $\beta > \tilde{\sigma}_p$, so that the investor advances $\sigma_p = \beta$ wherever it participates, leaving the seed investor $J(b) := I - \beta + b$ against a residual need $b = l - \sigma_a$. By (4) its profit at that amount is $W(J(b)) - \beta$, so write b^W for the residual need at which an investor advancing its whole budget breaks even—the solution of $W(J(b^W)) = \beta$, taken to be β where the condition never binds—and set $\bar{b} := \min\{\beta, b^W\}$.

Proposition 7 (Pre-funding investors). *On that branch:*

- (i) *a pre-seed round occurs if and only if the investor can cover the residual need and break even on it, $b \leq \beta$ and $W(J(b)) \geq \beta$; equivalently, if and only if $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{b}$;*
- (ii) *the financing threshold is then $\pi(J(b))$, strictly increasing in the shock;*
- (iii) *the probability of seed success is*

$$\mathbb{P}(\text{seed}) = G(\sigma_a)(1 - F(\pi_0)) + \int_{\sigma_a}^{\sigma_a + \bar{b}} \left(1 - F(\pi(J(l - \sigma_a)))\right) dG(l).$$

Two differences with Proposition 6 are worth naming. The product becomes an integral, because the shock distribution and the project distribution no longer separate: each shock now carries its own threshold. And the ordering $\pi_0 < \pi_{\min}^*$ can reverse, since a sufficiently pre-funded round leaves the seed investor less to contribute than no shock at all would have—a firm that suffers a small shock and meets a deep-pocketed investor ends up better placed than one that suffered none. That reversal is the subject of the qualification to Proposition 8 below.

This delivers the benchmark result announced at the outset of the section.

Proposition 8. *For a constrained pre-seed investor, increasing σ_a raises the probability of seed success, and raises the probability that no pre-seed round is needed.*

Both boundaries of Proposition 5 shift rightwards by the same amount, so firms move from the pre-seed region into the no-pre-seed region and out of liquidation, while π_0 , $\pi_{\min}^*$, ρ_p^* and $\bar{\sigma}_p$ are all unchanged—they depend on (ρ_a, I, F) only. The accelerator’s cash therefore works on the *extensive* margin, which firms need a pre-seed round at all, and not through the terms of that round.

That first half rests entirely on $\pi_0 < \pi_{\min}^*$: moving a firm out of the pre-seed region helps only if that region is the worse place to be. Once the investor pre-funds, the ordering is no longer automatic. On the pre-funding branch of Proposition 3 the threshold there is $\pi(J)$ with $J = I - \beta + b$, and since $\pi(\cdot)$ is increasing, $\pi(J) < \pi_0$ exactly when $J < J_0$, where J_0 is the residual investment cost the threshold equation associates with π_0 . Under (B) this requires $b < J_0$: only a firm whose residual need is smaller than J_0 , and whose investor spends its entire budget covering it and pre-funding the rest, ends up better placed than it would have been with no shock at all. The bound confines the reversal to a corner of the shock space rather than eliminating it. The second half—fewer firms need an interim round—holds regardless.

Figure 1 plots the whole equilibrium against the shock itself, holding every other parameter fixed: the three amounts, the three stakes, the two prices and the seed probability, each as a function of l . The partition is what one reads off the vertical lines—the pre-seed stake flat across the constrained region, and the seed probability a step function whose jumps are the boundaries the accelerator’s cash moves.

Table 2 collects the equilibrium of this section. Two primitives sort the firm: the liquidity shock l , which decides whether a pre-seed round is needed and whether it can be financed at all, and the pre-seed investor’s budget β , which decides how it is financed. Everything else in the table is a function of (ρ_a, I, F) and of those two. The two stakes are not independent entries: the seed investor prices to saturate the cap table, so $\rho_s^* = J/\pi(J)$ and the pre-seed stake is what is left of $1 - \rho_a$ once that is taken. Reading a column down therefore shows the same primitive twice—what the pre-seed investor takes is what the seed investor is left unable to claim. The accelerator’s two rows are constant across the table: its contract is signed before anything is known and nothing in the two rounds that follow revises it. That is exactly what Section 4 changes.

4 The accelerator’s MFN SAFE

Suppose the accelerator now invests σ_a against a headline share ρ_a^0 and, in addition, an amount m whose conversion price is

$$\min(V, V_p),$$

the more favourable of the seed price and the pre-seed price. That amount is an *uncapped SAFE carrying a most-favored-nation clause*—uncapped because it names no base of its own, and we call it the accelerator’s *MFN SAFE* for short. It automatically

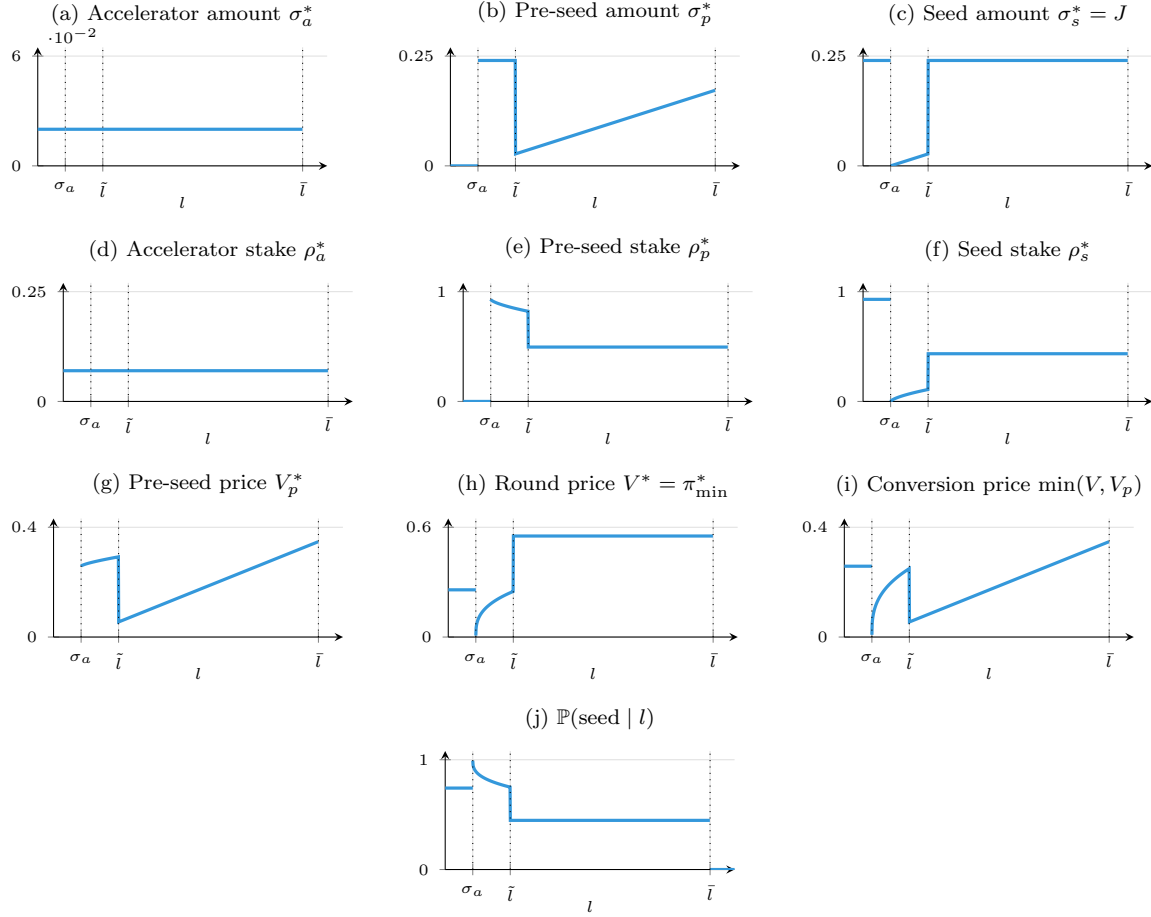


Figure 1: Equilibrium outcomes as functions of the liquidity shock l : the benchmark. Every other parameter is held fixed, so each panel is a cross-section of firms differing only in the shock they draw. Up to σ_a the accelerator's amount absorbs the shock and no pre-seed round takes place. Past it the investor enters and pre-funds—it advances its whole budget in (b), which is why the seed investor's residual cost in (c) starts near zero and climbs. At $\bar{l}$ the shock has eaten the pre-funding: from there the amount merely covers the shock, J is back at I , and panels (e), (f), (h) and (i) go flat. That flat stretch is the share invariance of Corollary 1, and it is what identifies the regime in data; the price in (g) keeps rising one-for-one with the amount raised. The accelerator's two panels are flat throughout: its contract is signed before the shock and nothing revises it. At $\bar{l}$ the shock exceeds what the investor can or will advance and the firm is liquidated. Drawn for f uniform on $[0, 1]$, $\rho_a = \rho_a^0 = 0.07$, $I = 0.24$, $\sigma_a = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.24$ —the budget is the largest Assumption (B) allows, $\beta = I$, which is what puts all three conversion regimes within reach: a smaller one confines the investor to the first. The parameters are illustrative: the levels of the stakes reflect the monopolistic closure, and it is their shape in l that the figure is about.

	(N) no pre-seed	(P) constrained	(P) pre-funding	(L) liquidation
	$l \leq \sigma_a$	$\beta \leq \tilde{\sigma}_p$	$\beta > \tilde{\sigma}_p$	l beyond the cap
Accelerator σ_a^*	σ_a	σ_a	σ_a	σ_a
Accelerator ρ_a^*	ρ_a	ρ_a	ρ_a	ρ_a
Pre-seed σ_p^*	0	$l - \sigma_a$	β	—
Pre-seed ρ_p^*	0	$1 - \rho_a - \frac{I}{\pi(I)}$	$1 - \rho_a - \frac{J}{\pi(J)}$	—
Seed $\sigma_s^* = J$	I	I	$I - \beta + l - \sigma_a$	—
Seed ρ_s^*	$1 - \rho_a$	$\frac{I}{\pi(I)}$	$\frac{J}{\pi(J)}$	—
Pre-seed price V_p^*	—	$\frac{I}{l - \sigma_a}$	$\frac{J}{\beta}$	—
Round price $V^* = \pi_{\min}^*$	$\frac{I}{1 - \rho_a}$	$\pi(I)$	$\pi(J)$	—
$\mathbb{P}(\text{seed} \mid \cdot)$	$1 - F\left(\frac{I}{1 - \rho_a}\right)$	$1 - F(\pi(I))$	$1 - F(\pi(J))$	0

Table 2: Equilibrium of the benchmark, by regime. Every entry is a function of the primitives $(\rho_a, \sigma_a, I, \beta, l)$ and of the distributions, through the threshold map $\pi(\cdot)$ of Corollary 1—the root of $\Phi(\cdot; J)$, which depends on ρ_a , on the residual investment cost, and on f . In the pre-funding column the pre-seed investor advances β , of which $\beta - (l - \sigma_a)$ is left in the firm, so the seed investor's amount is $\sigma_s^* = J = I - \beta + l - \sigma_a$; in the two other financed columns $\sigma_s^* = J = I$. The remaining rows are written in J rather than in that expression, since J is the argument of the threshold map $\pi(\cdot)$ throughout the paper. The two (P) columns share the shock conditions $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$ and $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{b}$ respectively and are separated by the budget cutoff $\tilde{\sigma}_p$ of Proposition 3; $\bar{\sigma}_p = W(I)$ and $\bar{b} = \min\{\beta, b^W\}$ are the participation caps of Propositions 4 and 7. The cap table saturates (Proposition 1), so $\rho_a + \rho_p^* + \rho_s^* = 1$ in every financed column, and the round is priced at the marginal project, so $V^* = \pi_{\min}^*$. The threshold is constant across the constrained column and rising in the shock in the pre-funding one, which is the single difference between them.

adopts the best terms granted to any investor entering before the first priced round, and in this environment there is exactly one such investor—the one that covers the interim shock.

The expression $\min(V, V_p)$ will reappear in Remark 2 attached to a different contract, so it is worth fixing what an MFN clause is. It carries *no base of its own*: it converts at the best price obtained by any investor entering after its holder. Here the accelerator has two such investors, at prices V_p and V , and neither is a number it chose—which is what makes the clause a remedy for having committed first. A valuation cap, by contrast, adds a base the holder specifies to that minimum. The two coincide algebraically whenever the holder has a single successor, as the pre-seed investor does, and Remark 2 shows what that coincidence is worth here.

Such a contract has two distinct channels, which we treat in turn: a *cash* channel, since the accelerator’s committed amount rises, and an *MFN* channel, since the term $m/\min(V, V_p)$ enters the capitalization table. The two need not push in the same direction, and separating them is the purpose of what follows.

4.1 The cash channel

The first channel is not new: it is Proposition 8, established in the benchmark. Raising σ_a moves the two boundaries of Proposition 5 rightwards, enlarging the no-pre-seed region and shrinking the liquidation region, and it does so without touching the terms of the pre-seed round—the equilibrium stake ρ_p^* and threshold $\pi_{\min}^*$ are the same numbers before and after. The cash component therefore acts on the *extensive* margin alone, and favourably.

4.2 The MFN channel

At $t = 7$ the seed investor now solves

$$\max_V \int \left(\frac{J}{V(\pi)} \pi - J \right) f(\pi) d\pi \quad \text{subject to} \quad \rho_a^0 + \frac{m}{\min(V, V_p)} + \rho_p + \frac{J}{V} \leq 1.$$

As in the benchmark the objective is strictly increasing in the seed share, so the cap table binds. Which of the two prices the MFN SAFE converts at determines the shape of the constraint, and hence the equilibrium valuation:

$$V = \begin{cases} \frac{J + m}{1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p}} & \text{if } V < V_p \quad (\text{it converts at the round price}), \\ \frac{J}{1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{\sigma_p + m}{V_p}} & \text{if } V > V_p \quad (\text{it converts at the pre-seed price}). \end{cases}$$

Write

$$\widehat{V}_p := \frac{J + m + \sigma_p}{1 - \rho_a^0}$$

for the pre-seed price at which the two branches meet.

Lemma 4. $V < V_p$ if and only if $V_p > \widehat{V}_p$, and $V > V_p$ if and only if $V_p < \widehat{V}_p$.

The economics is worth stating plainly. A pre-seed investor that prices the company *low* ($V_p < \widehat{V}_p$) hands the accelerator's MFN SAFE a cheap conversion: the MFN SAFE converts at V_p and lands in the pre-seed block of the cap table. A pre-seed investor that prices the company *high* ($V_p > \widehat{V}_p$) pushes the MFN SAFE into the seed round, where it converts at V and is borne by the seed investor. The pre-seed investor therefore chooses, through its own valuation, who pays for the accelerator's clause.

4.3 Pricing under the clause

The pre-seed investor's objective is unchanged in form, $\Pi_p(V_p) = \sigma_p(M(\pi_{\min}(V_p))/V_p - 1)$, but $\pi_{\min}(\cdot)$ now depends on the regime. Since $\pi_{\min} = V$, Lemma 4 gives

$$\frac{\partial \pi_{\min}}{\partial V_p} = \begin{cases} -\frac{\pi_{\min}^2}{J + m} \cdot \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} & \text{if } V_p > \widehat{V}_p, \\ -\frac{\pi_{\min}^2}{J} \cdot \frac{\sigma_p + m}{V_p^2} & \text{if } V_p < \widehat{V}_p, \end{cases}$$

and, proceeding exactly as in Proposition 2,

$$\Pi'_p(V_p) = \begin{cases} \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} \left(\frac{\sigma_p f(\pi_{\min}) \pi_{\min}^3}{(J + m) V_p} - M(\pi_{\min}) \right) & \text{if } V_p > \widehat{V}_p, \\ \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} \left(\frac{(\sigma_p + m) f(\pi_{\min}) \pi_{\min}^3}{J V_p} - M(\pi_{\min}) \right) & \text{if } V_p < \widehat{V}_p. \end{cases}$$

Substituting the cap-table identity of each regime— $(\sigma_p + m)/V_p = 1 - \rho_a^0 - J/\pi_{\min}$ in the low-price regime, $\sigma_p/V_p = 1 - \rho_a^0 - (J + m)/\pi_{\min}$ in the high-price regime—the two first-order conditions collapse onto a single family of equations, which is the observation the rest of the section rests on.

Definition 1. For $J > 0$ let

$$\Phi(\pi; J) := (1 - \rho_a^0) \pi^3 f(\pi) - J \left(\pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi) \right), \quad \pi \in (0, 1].$$

Lemma 5. *The interior optimum of the pre-seed investor satisfies*

$$\begin{aligned} \Phi(\pi_{\min}; J) &= 0 & \text{in the low-price regime } V_p < \widehat{V}_p, \\ \Phi(\pi_{\min}; J + m) &= 0 & \text{in the high-price regime } V_p > \widehat{V}_p. \end{aligned}$$

Lemma 5 is the pivot of the paper. The two regimes are governed by the *same* equation, evaluated at two different effective investment costs: J when the pre-seed investor absorbs the MFN SAFE into its own block, and $J + m$ when it pushes the MFN SAFE into the seed round. Everything that follows is a comparison of the two roots.

4.4 The two thresholds and their order

We first record a restriction without which no pre-seed round can occur at all.

Lemma 6. *If $J + m \geq 1 - \rho_a^0$, the pre-seed investor never participates.*

We therefore maintain $J + m < 1 - \rho_a^0$ throughout. No further restriction on f is needed: the log-concavity already assumed in (A1) delivers the threshold.

Lemma 7. *Fix J with $0 < J < 1 - \rho_a^0$. Then $\Phi(\cdot; J)$ has a unique root π_J in $(J/(1 - \rho_a^0), 1)$, and $\Phi(\pi; J) < 0$ for $\pi < \pi_J$ and $\Phi(\pi; J) > 0$ for $\pi > \pi_J$ on that interval.*

Two roots are used from here on. Write $\pi_1 := \pi(J)$ for the root at the residual investment cost the pre-seed investor leaves and $\pi_2 := \pi(J + m)$ for the root at $J + m$; since $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing (Lemma 2), $\pi_1 < \pi_2$.

The two are the same problem at two investment costs, and that is the whole of the MFN channel. When the pre-seed investor absorbs the clause into its own block, the seed investor still has to fund J and the threshold solves $\Phi(\cdot; J) = 0$ —the benchmark equation of Corollary 1 with ρ_a^0 in place of ρ_a , so the threshold is the one the benchmark engineers. When the claim is pushed into the round, the seed investor must clear $J + m$ out of the same capitalization table, and the threshold rises to π_2 . Pushing the clause on therefore costs the firm the projects between π_1 and π_2 . Which of the two prevails is the subject of Section 4.5.

Example 1 (uniform density). Let $\pi \sim U[0, 1]$, so $f \equiv 1$ and $M(x) = (1 - x^2)/2$. Then

$$\Phi(\pi; J) = (1 - \rho_a^0)\pi^3 - \frac{J}{2}(\pi^2 + 1),$$

and $f \equiv 1$ is log-concave. With $\rho_a^0 = 0.07$ and $J = 0.24$ one obtains $\pi_1 \approx 0.552$, and adding a tranche of $m = 0.025$ gives $\pi_2 \approx 0.574$: the gap is the set of projects financed when the pre-seed investor absorbs the clause and abandoned when it pushes it into the round. The pivot is $\bar{x} = \sqrt{2} - 1 \approx 0.414$, so π_1 and π_2 both sit above it at $J = I$ and below it once the investor pre-funds heavily—which is why all three regimes appear in Figures 1–3. These are the parameters used there, and they are illustrative.

4.5 Where the clause converts: three regimes

Which conversion regime is played is decided by the amount, and two thresholds separate the three possibilities. Write

$$T_1 := (1 - \rho_a^0) \pi_1 - (J + m), \quad T_2 := (1 - \rho_a^0) \pi_2 - (J + m), \quad (7)$$

so that $T_1 < T_2$ because $\pi_1 < \pi_2$. Each is the amount at which one of the two unconstrained optima leaves the region of prices that can support it: $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ is $\pi_1 \geq \widehat{V}_p$, and $\sigma_p \leq T_2$ is $\pi_2 \geq \widehat{V}_p$. Because $\sigma_p + J = b + I$ whatever the investor pre-funds, both comparisons are conditions on the residual need alone: $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ if and only if $b + I + m \leq (1 - \rho_a^0) \pi_1$.

Proposition 9 (Pricing regimes). *At a given amount, the pre-seed investor's optimal price, the threshold it engineers and the capitalization table it leaves are the following, with $k = 1 - \rho_a^0$ throughout.*

(i) *If $\sigma_p \leq T_1$, the clause converts inside the pre-seed block:*

$$V_p^* = \frac{\sigma_p + m}{k - J/\pi_1} < V, \quad \pi_{\min}^* = \pi_1,$$

$$\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + \left(k - \frac{J}{\pi_1}\right) \frac{m}{\sigma_p + m}, \quad \rho_p^* = \left(k - \frac{J}{\pi_1}\right) \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m}, \quad \rho_s^* = \frac{J}{\pi_1}.$$

(ii) *If $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$, the two prices coincide at $V_p^* = V = \widehat{V}_p = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k$, and*

$$\pi_{\min}^* = \widehat{V}_p, \quad \rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + \frac{k m}{J + m + \sigma_p}, \quad \rho_p^* = \frac{k \sigma_p}{J + m + \sigma_p}, \quad \rho_s^* = \frac{k J}{J + m + \sigma_p}.$$

(iii) *If $\sigma_p > T_2$, the clause converts into the round:*

$$V_p^* = \frac{\sigma_p}{k - (J + m)/\pi_2} > V, \quad \pi_{\min}^* = \pi_2,$$

$$\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + \frac{m}{\pi_2}, \quad \rho_p^* = k - \frac{J + m}{\pi_2}, \quad \rho_s^* = \frac{J}{\pi_2}.$$

In each case the round is priced at $V = \pi_{\min}^$ and the conditional probability of a seed round is $1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)$.*

The amount decides who pays for the clause. An investor advancing a small one absorbs it: the price it would name anyway is low enough that the accelerator's claim converts alongside its own, and the two share the block $k - J/\pi_1$ in the proportions $m : \sigma_p$. An investor advancing a large one prices high enough to push the claim into the round, where the seed investor carries it out of a table that must still fund J .

Between the two it prices exactly at the round, and the three claims convert together on one base.

Read as instruments, the three regimes are three different contracts written on the same piece of paper. In (i) the accelerator's claim converts at a base strictly below the round, which is the payoff of a capped SAFE whose cap binds—the cap being the price the pre-seed investor names. In (ii) and (iii) it converts at the round itself, which is the payoff of an uncapped SAFE, and the clause is inert on the price margin. What separates those two is not the accelerator's instrument but what the pre-seed investor pays for its own block: the round price in (ii), more than it in (iii). The regimes are therefore ordered by the ratio V_p^*/V , below one in (i), equal to one throughout (ii), above one in (iii). The seed investor's stake is J/V in all three, so that ratio and the seed investor's stake move against each other.

What that does to financing follows from the ordering $\pi_1 < \pi_2$, and it is not the same in the three regimes.

Corollary 2 (The clause and the threshold). *Compare each regime with the benchmark of Corollary 1 at the same residual investment cost J .*

- (i) *On $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the threshold is unchanged at $\pi_{\min}^* = \pi(J)$: the seed investor's stake $J/\pi(J)$ and the financing probability are the benchmark's, and the clause moves m/V_p^* points of equity from the pre-seed investor to the accelerator and nothing else.*
- (ii) *On $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$ it raises the threshold to $\hat{V}_p \in (\pi_1, \pi_2]$, strictly above the benchmark, and $\hat{V}_p$ rises one-for-one with the amount.*
- (iii) *On $\sigma_p > T_2$ it raises the threshold to $\pi_2 = \pi(J + m)$: the benchmark threshold of a round that costs $J + m$ instead of J .*

At a given residual cost and a given amount, the probability of a seed round is therefore weakly lower under the clause, strictly so at every amount above T_1 .

The three regimes are the whole of the MFN channel, and the clause is not one thing across them. It redistributes without cost in the first, and it destroys financing states in the other two, by a margin that grows with σ_p until it settles at the gap $\pi_2 - \pi_1$. All of that is read at a fixed residual cost, where the amount is exogenous to the comparison. At a fixed shock it is not, and Proposition 19 shows the sign does not survive that change of conditioning. Which of the regimes a firm meets is itself not a matter of taste, because the investor must also want to participate, and participation caps the amount. Where that cap falls relative to T_1 and T_2 is settled by one comparison: the position of the pivot $\bar{x}$, the solution of $M(\bar{x}) = \bar{x}$, against the two thresholds. Since $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing with $\pi(J^\dagger) = \bar{x}$, that is the position of $J^\dagger$ against J and $J + m$.

Proposition 10 (Participation). *The pre-seed investor participates if and only if $\sigma_p \leq \bar{\sigma}_p^m$, where*

$$\bar{\sigma}_p^m = \begin{cases} W(J) - m & \text{if } J \geq J^\dagger, \text{ that is } \bar{x} \leq \pi_1, \\ (1 - \rho_a^0) \bar{x} - (J + m) & \text{if } J < J^\dagger \leq J + m, \text{ that is } \pi_1 < \bar{x} \leq \pi_2, \\ W(J + m) & \text{if } J + m < J^\dagger, \text{ that is } \pi_2 < \bar{x}, \end{cases}$$

and these caps satisfy $\bar{\sigma}_p^m \leq T_1$, $T_1 < \bar{\sigma}_p^m \leq T_2$ and $\bar{\sigma}_p^m > T_2$ respectively. A participating investor therefore reaches the first regime alone, the first two, or all three.

One comparison read at three heights, and it says something simple. Everything turns on whether the projects that survive the threshold are worth more than the price at which the marginal one is financed, $M(\pi)$ against π , and $\bar{x}$ is where the two cross. Below the pivot a claim is still worth engineering a higher threshold for; above it, raising the bar destroys more than it collects. An investor can therefore afford to price its way out of the clause only when its threshold sits below the pivot—which, by Proposition 3, is the pre-funding branch. One that merely covers the shock leaves $J = I \geq J^\dagger$ and never leaves the first regime; one that pre-funds drives J down, and with it π_1 and then π_2 below the pivot, until all three are open to it.

That is the MFN channel stated in full: the threshold is unchanged where the investor advances the shock and no more, and rises where it pre-funds. The same cash that lowers the bar through J is what opens the regimes that raise it, and the two effects meet in Section 4.7.

4.6 When the pre-seed investor holds the same clause

Throughout, the pre-seed investor has held a *fixed-base* claim: it names a base V_p , buys $\rho_p = \sigma_p/V_p$, and keeps that share whatever the round price turns out to be. Suppose instead that it secures for itself the protection the accelerator holds against it—conversion at the more favourable of the two bases, so that its share becomes

$$\frac{\sigma_p}{\min(V, V_p)},$$

exactly the form of the accelerator’s MFN SAFE. In market terms this is the standard capped SAFE, whose holder converts at the lower of its cap and the round price; we call it a *best-price* claim to keep the mechanism rather than the product name in view. The question is not which of two products is better, but what happens when the clause is held by an investor who could otherwise have set its own price.

The seed investor’s problem. Both claims now convert at $\min(V, V_p)$, so the saturated capitalization table reads

$$\rho_a^0 + \frac{m}{\min(V, V_p)} + \frac{\sigma_p}{\min(V, V_p)} + \frac{J}{V} = 1,$$

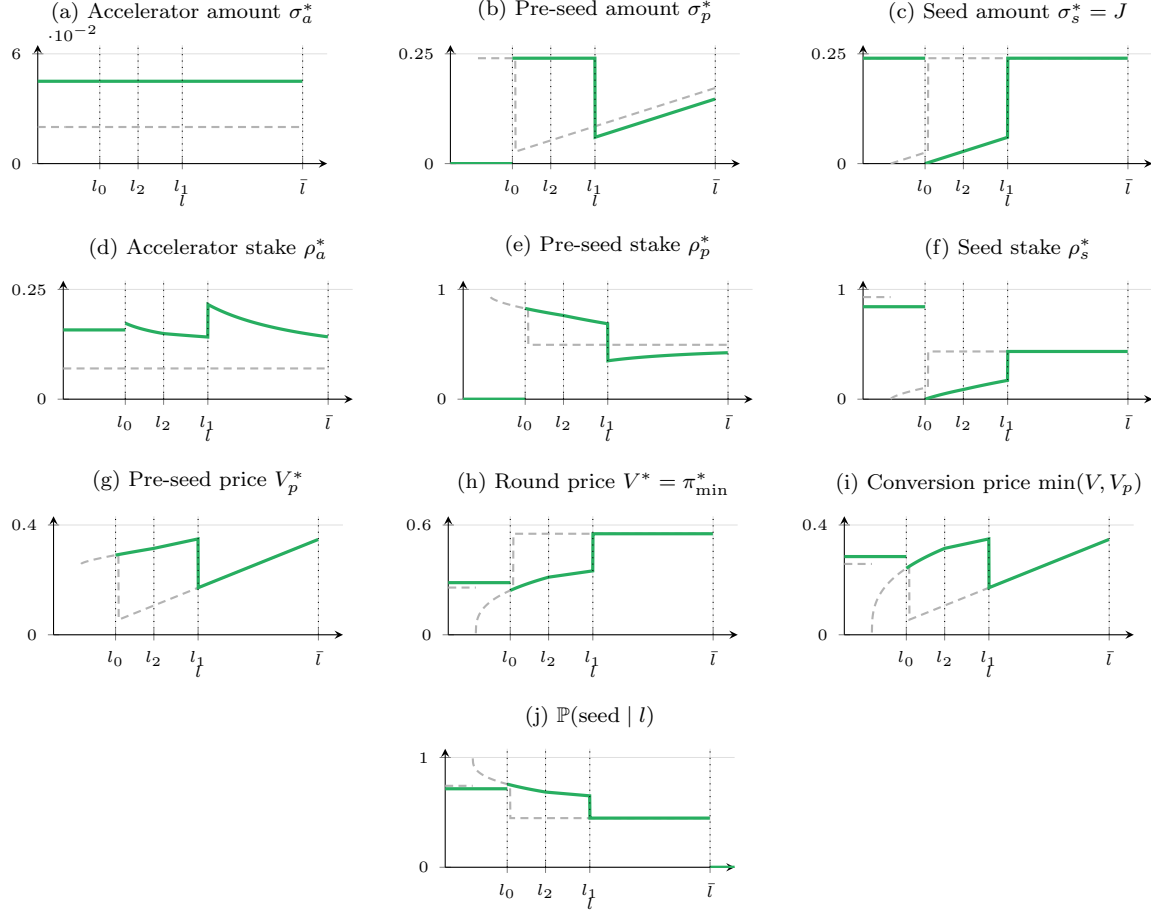


Figure 2: The same outcomes once the accelerator also holds an MFN SAFE, in green, against the benchmark of Figure 1 in dashed grey; $l_0 = \sigma_a + m$ is the entry point. The cash channel moves that point from σ_a to l_0 . The MFN channel is panel (d): the accelerator's stake is no longer the constant ρ_a^0 but $\rho_a^0 + m / \min(V, V_p^*)$, worth most where the round it converts alongside is smallest. The three conversion regimes of Proposition 9 appear here in reverse order, and the reason is worth stating: the proposition orders them in the amount, but a budget-constrained investor that pre-funds advances the *same* amount β at every shock, so what moves with l is not σ_p but the cutoffs T_1, T_2 , through the residual cost J . Small shocks therefore sit in regime (iii), where the SAFE is pushed into the round and the threshold in (h) is π_2 ; $[l_2, l_1]$ is regime (ii), where (g) and (h) coincide; and past l_1 the investor absorbs the clause in its own price and the threshold is π_1 . Drawn for f uniform on $[0, 1]$, $\rho_a = \rho_a^0 = 0.07$, $I = 0.24$, $\sigma_a = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.24$, $m = 0.025$ —the budget is the largest Assumption (B) allows, $\beta = I$, which is what puts all three conversion regimes within reach: a smaller one confines the investor to the first. The parameters are illustrative: the levels of the stakes reflect the monopolistic closure, and it is their shape in l that the figure is about.

and therefore

$$V = \begin{cases} \frac{J + m + \sigma_p}{1 - \rho_a^0} = \widehat{V}_p & \text{if } V < V_p \quad (\text{the cap does not bind}), \\ \frac{J}{1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{m + \sigma_p}{V_p}} & \text{if } V > V_p \quad (\text{the cap binds}), \end{cases}$$

the first branch obtaining when $V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p$ and the second when $V_p < \widehat{V}_p$, exactly as in Lemma 4 and with the same cutoff. The asymmetry with the fixed-base case is immediate, and it is the whole of the argument: above $\widehat{V}_p$ the round price no longer depends on V_p . Once the cap stops binding, the pre-seed investor's pricing decision has no effect on anything.

The pre-seed investor's problem. The objective is $\Pi_p(V_p) = \sigma_p(M(\pi_{\min})/\min(V, V_p) - 1)$. Below $\widehat{V}_p$ the cap binds, conversion occurs at V_p , and $\pi_{\min} = J/(k - (m + \sigma_p)/V_p)$, so that

$$\frac{\partial \pi_{\min}}{\partial V_p} = -\frac{\pi_{\min}^2}{J} \cdot \frac{\sigma_p + m}{V_p^2} < 0, \quad \Pi'_p(V_p) = \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} \left(\frac{(\sigma_p + m)f(\pi_{\min})\pi_{\min}^3}{J V_p} - M(\pi_{\min}) \right),$$

and substituting the capitalization identity $(m + \sigma_p)/V_p = k - J/\pi_{\min}$ returns $\Phi(\pi_{\min}; J) = 0$: the same equation as the low-price regime of Lemma 5, with the same interior optimum π_1 . Above $\widehat{V}_p$ the cap does not bind, conversion occurs at $V = \widehat{V}_p$, and both price and threshold are constants,

$$\Pi_p(V_p) = \sigma_p \left(\frac{M(\widehat{V}_p)}{\widehat{V}_p} - 1 \right) \quad \text{for every } V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p,$$

so $\Pi'_p = 0$ on that entire range: every valuation above the cutoff is optimal and all of them pay the same.

Proposition 11 (Best-price regimes). *Under a best-price claim the pre-seed investor's problem has two regimes rather than three:*

- (i) if $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the cap binds, the claim converts at $V_p^* = (\sigma_p + m)/(k - J/\pi_1)$, and the threshold is π_1 , exactly as under a fixed-base claim;
- (ii) if $\sigma_p > T_1$ the cap does not bind: every $V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p$ is optimal, all of them deliver the same payoff, and the threshold is $\widehat{V}_p$.

On small amounts the two instruments therefore coincide, and this is what makes the market's default coherent.

Remark 2 (A cap that never binds is a price). On $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the best-price claim prices strictly below the round, so the minimum is always its own base and it converts at V_p^* : a capped SAFE and a fixed-base SAFE are the *same contract* there. The cap is worth exactly the price its holder would have named, and choosing between the two instruments is immaterial.

The capped, no-discount SAFE is the dominant pre-seed structure, held by roughly three in four SAFE investors by late 2025 (Carta, 2025), and the model says that an investor advancing amounts below T_1 gives up nothing by holding it. By Proposition 10 that covers every amount available to an investor that merely bridges the shock. Past T_1 the two part company, and the comparison runs against the protection.

Proposition 12 (The clause constrains a holder who can price). *The best-price claim is weakly dominated by the fixed-base claim for the pre-seed investor, and strictly dominated whenever $\sigma_p > T_2$. The domination is strict at an amount the investor would actually advance only if $\pi_1 < \bar{x}$; where the first regime is the only one participation allows, the two claims are worth the same at every such amount.*

The comparison extends to the two claimants the proposition does not name.

Proposition 13 (The best-price claim and the three payoffs). *At a given amount and residual investment cost, the two instruments deliver the same Π_p , Π_a and Π_s on $\sigma_p \leq T_2$. On $\sigma_p > T_2$ the threshold is π_2 under the fixed-base claim and $\hat{V}_p > \pi_2$ under the best-price claim, and all three payoffs are strictly lower under the latter.*

The capitalization table is saturated in both, so the three claimants hold the company between them: past T_2 the best-price claim is worth less to each of them at once, and not to its holder alone.

The contrast with Proposition 9 is the point. Holding a fixed-base claim the investor has three regimes and still optimizes on large amounts: it prices high, pushes the accelerator’s claim into the round, and attains π_2 . Holding a best-price claim the high-price branch collapses—the cap hands the round the conversion, the threshold sticks at $\hat{V}_p$, and the investor loses the ability to price at all.

The economics runs against instinct. The clause is a guarantee, and it delivers what it promises: its holder converts on the better of the two bases. But conversion is not a transfer from someone outside the company—it is a claim on the same capitalization table that must also accommodate J . By loading that table precisely in the states where the round prices low, the clause raises the threshold above which a round happens at all, and so destroys the states in which the claim pays anything. The protection works through a cap-table externality that turns against its own holder, and waiving it is a commitment device: it leaves room for the seed investor and buys back the financing states.

That is a statement about holders rather than about clauses. The accelerator commits at admission, before anything is known, and cannot revise its terms; for it the clause

is pure gain, since it recovers a base it could never have negotiated. The pre-seed investor arrives after the shock and *sets* a price; for it the same clause substitutes a mechanical conversion rule for a decision it was making optimally, and the substitution can only weakly help. The condition $\pi_1 < \bar{x}$ says when the difference is more than weak: it is the pre-funding branch of Proposition 3, where the investor advances large amounts—and large amounts are exactly where a rule that fixes the conversion price costs the most.

4.7 What the clause does to the amount

Propositions 9 and 10 hold the amount fixed. Once it is a choice again, the clause acquires a second margin, and the first regime is silent about it.

Proposition 14. *In the first regime of Proposition 9, at amount σ_p and residual investment cost J ,*

$$\frac{\partial \Pi_p}{\partial \Delta} = \frac{m W(J)}{(\sigma_p + m)^2} + \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m} \Lambda(J) - 1,$$

which exceeds its no-clause counterpart $\Lambda(J) - 1$ of Lemma 3 by

$$\frac{m M(\pi_1)}{\sigma_p + m} \left[\frac{1}{V_p^*} - \frac{1}{\pi_1} \right] \geq 0,$$

strictly whenever $V_p^ < V$. The MFN SAFE therefore weakly raises the pre-seed investor's incentive to pre-fund the seed round, strictly wherever it prices below the round.*

The mechanism is a dilution asymmetry, and it is visible in the fraction $\sigma_p/(\sigma_p + m)$ alone. The MFN SAFE removes a *fixed number of units* from the pre-seed investor's block, so it costs a small amount proportionally far more than a large one, and advancing a bigger amount is among other things a way of diluting the clause. The clause, by taxing small amounts, pushes the investor toward exactly the behaviour that lowers the financing threshold, and this is the one margin the reform moves in a single direction.

The prediction about *amounts* is therefore unambiguous where the threshold predictions were not: pre-seed rounds should get larger, and larger by more than the mechanical substitution the cash channel produces. But the same force has a second destination, and it is the one the rest of the paper has been building toward.

Corollary 3 (The clause widens its own pre-funding region). *The pivot of Proposition 3 falls under the clause, $\tilde{\Delta}^m \leq \tilde{\Delta}$, strictly wherever the investor prices below the round. The set of budgets at which the investor pre-funds rather than merely covering the shock is therefore larger with the clause than without it.*

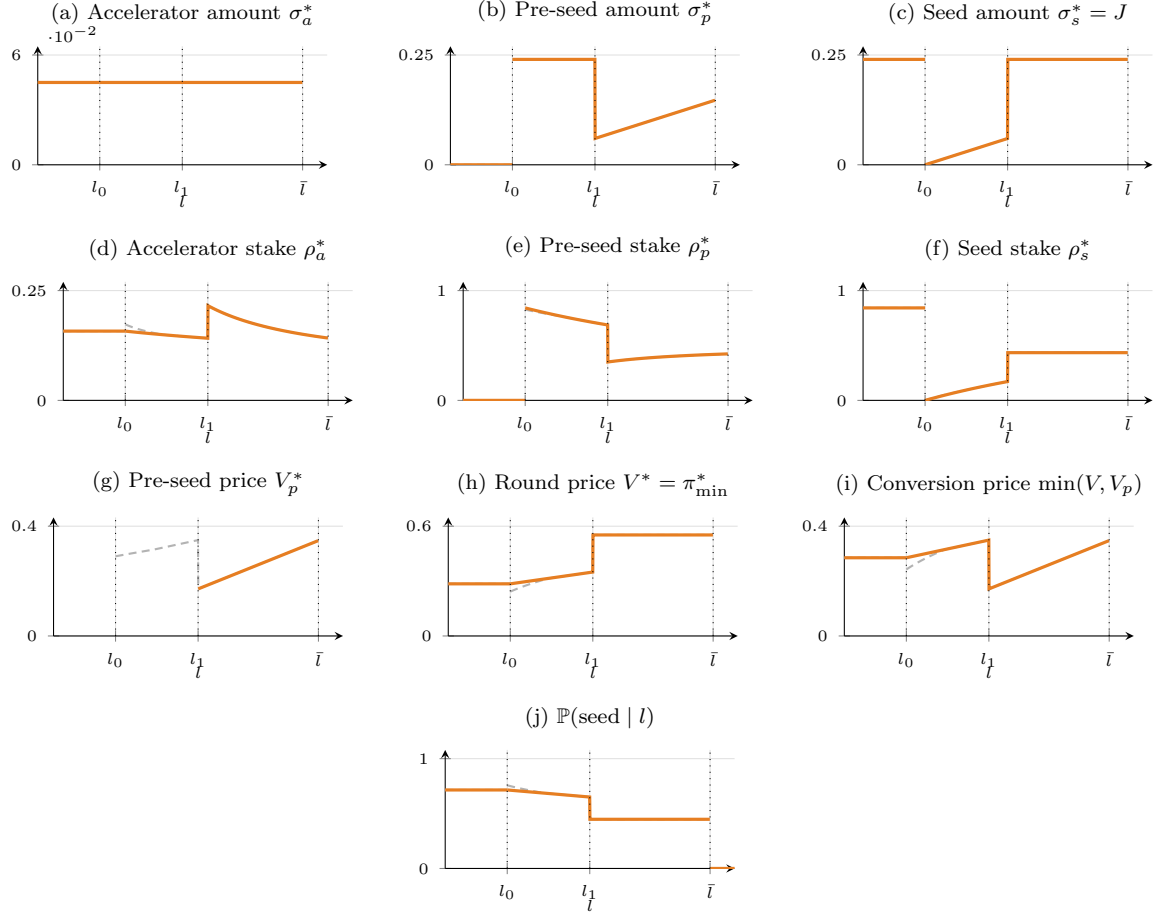


Figure 3: The same outcomes when the pre-seed investor holds a best-price claim rather than a fixed base, in orange, against the fixed-base case of Figure 2 in dashed grey. The two coincide wherever the cap binds, which by Proposition 11 is every shock past l_1 : there the clause costs its holder nothing, which is Remark 2. Below l_1 the difference is Proposition 12: the fixed-base investor has a high-price branch and rides it at the threshold π_2 , whereas the best-price investor has none—its claim converts at the round price whatever base it names, so (g) is undefined, the threshold in (h) is pushed up to $\widehat{V}_p$ and the seed probability in (j) is strictly lower. The protection binds exactly where it hurts. Drawn for f uniform on $[0, 1]$, $\rho_a = \rho_a^0 = 0.07$, $I = 0.24$, $\sigma_a = 0.02$, $\beta = 0.24$, $m = 0.025$ —the budget is the largest Assumption (B) allows, $\beta = I$, which is what puts all three conversion regimes within reach: a smaller one confines the investor to the first. The parameters are illustrative: the levels of the stakes reflect the monopolistic closure, and it is their shape in l that the figure is about.

Put the corollary beside Proposition 10 and the shape of the result appears. Pre-funding is what drives J down; J falling below $J^\dagger$ is what opens regimes (ii) and (iii); and those are the regimes in which the threshold rises and financing states are destroyed. The clause taxes the small amount, the investor answers with a larger one, and a large enough amount is what carries the clause into the round. *The instrument pushes the investor toward the region in which the instrument ceases to be harmless.*

Two things keep this from being a clean welfare verdict, and both should be stated. The same pre-funding lowers J , and a lower J lowers the financing threshold within any given regime—so the identical move helps on one margin while opening the door on the other. And the door only opens if the budget reaches that far: an investor bounded well below I writes larger amounts under the clause and still never approaches T_1 . The model therefore does not sign the sum. What it does is identify the quantity that decides it—how much intermediate investors pre-fund, relative to the round they bridge to—and say why that ratio, rather than the drafting of any clause, is what a regulator or an accelerator would have to look at.

Table 3 collects the section, putting the benchmark beside each of the three regimes. The accelerator’s row is the novelty throughout: its stake is no longer the constant ρ_a but a share the pre-seed investor’s own price determines. Below that row the columns part company. In regime (i) everything matches the benchmark—the seed investor advances the same amount, holds the same share, and finances the same set of projects. In (ii) and (iii) it does not: the seed stake and the round price move with the clause, and the set of financed projects shrinks. The amount itself is the corner of Proposition 3 evaluated at the accelerator’s reformed contribution $\sigma_a + m$: the pre-seed investor advances the residual need $l - \sigma_a - m$ when its budget binds and β when it does not, so that $J = I$ in the first case and $J = I - \beta + l - \sigma_a - m$ in the second.

Read down the columns rather than across the rows: two prices generate every entry. Write V^* for the price of the round and $P^* := \min(V^*, V_p^*)$ for the price at which the accelerator’s MFN SAFE converts—the better of the two, which is what the clause entitles it to. Then in all three regimes

$$\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + \frac{m}{P^*}, \quad \rho_s^* = \frac{J}{V^*}, \quad \rho_p^* = k - \frac{J}{V^*} - \frac{m}{P^*}, \quad V_p^* = \frac{\sigma_p}{\rho_p^*}, \quad (8)$$

and the benchmark column is the same four expressions at $m = 0$. The three stakes sum to k by construction, so the pre-seed investor holds whatever the seed investor and the MFN SAFE leave, and the whole table moves with V^* and P^* alone. Both are pinned by the amount, and both rise with it: the MFN SAFE converts at the pre-seed price while that price sits below the round, at the common price on the middle range, and at the round beyond T_2 .

Proposition 15 (The order of the table). *Fix J and m and let the amount vary. Under (A1):*

	Benchmark	With the MFN SAFE		
		(i) $\sigma_p \leq T_1$	(ii) $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$	(iii) $\sigma_p > T_2$
Accelerator σ_a^*	σ_a		$\sigma_a + m$	
Accelerator ρ_a^*	ρ_a	$\rho_a^0 + \left(k - \frac{J}{\pi_1}\right) \frac{m}{\sigma_p + m}$	$\rho_a^0 + \frac{k m}{J + m + \sigma_p}$	$\rho_a^0 + \frac{m}{\pi_2}$
Pre-seed σ_p^*		$l - \sigma_a$ (resp. $l - \sigma_a - m$) if the budget binds, β if not		
Pre-seed ρ_p^*	$k - \frac{J}{\pi_1}$	$\left(k - \frac{J}{\pi_1}\right) \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m}$	$\frac{k \sigma_p}{J + m + \sigma_p}$	$k - \frac{J + m}{\pi_2}$
Seed $\sigma_s^* = J$		I if the budget binds, $I - \beta + l - \sigma_a$ (resp. $-m$) if not		
Seed ρ_s^*	$\frac{J}{\pi_1}$	$\frac{J}{\pi_1}$	$\frac{k J}{J + m + \sigma_p}$	$\frac{J}{\pi_2}$
Pre-seed price V_p^*	$\frac{\sigma_p}{k - J/\pi_1}$	$\frac{\sigma_p + m}{k - J/\pi_1}$	$\widehat{V}_p$	$\frac{\sigma_p}{k - (J + m)/\pi_2}$
Round price $V^* = \pi_{\min}^*$	π_1	π_1	$\widehat{V}_p$	π_2
$\mathbb{P}(\text{seed} \mid \cdot)$	$1 - F(\pi_1)$	$1 - F(\pi_1)$	$1 - F(\widehat{V}_p)$	$1 - F(\pi_2)$
Reached when	—	always	$J < J^\dagger$	$J + m < J^\dagger$

Table 3: Equilibrium with and without the accelerator’s MFN SAFE, on the template of Table 2. Here $k = 1 - \rho_a$ in the benchmark and $k = 1 - \rho_a^0$ under the clause; $\pi_1 = \pi(J)$ and $\pi_2 = \pi(J + m)$ are the threshold map of Corollary 1 at the seed investor’s residual cost and at that cost plus the tranche; and $\widehat{V}_p = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k$. The three columns are the regimes of Proposition 9, and the last row records which amounts a participating investor can advance (Proposition 10). Column (i) is the benchmark with one change: the total convertible share $k - J/\pi_1$ is the same object in both, split between the accelerator and the pre-seed investor in the proportions $m : \sigma_p$, so the seed stake, the round price and the financing probability are untouched. Columns (ii) and (iii) are not: the threshold rises, first with the amount and then to $\pi(J + m)$, and the financing probability falls with it. The accelerator’s extra cash shifts the shock at which a pre-seed round becomes necessary, which is why the amount and the residual cost carry the m correction under the clause. Proposition 15 orders the columns of every row.

- (i) $\sigma_p \mapsto V^*$ and $\sigma_p \mapsto P^*$ are continuous and non-decreasing, strictly increasing on $(T_1, T_2]$ and on $(0, T_2]$ respectively. Every entry of (8) is therefore continuous at T_1 and at T_2 , the two prices meeting at π_1 and at π_2 there.
- (ii) Across the three regimes the accelerator's stake and the seed investor's stake fall, while the pre-seed stake, the pre-seed price, the round price and the threshold rise; the probability of a seed round falls with the last of these.
- (iii) Against the benchmark at the same amount, the same residual cost and an unchanged headline share $\rho_a^0 = \rho_a$: the pre-seed stake is strictly lower and the pre-seed valuation strictly higher in all three regimes, while the seed stake, the round price and the financing probability are the benchmark's in regime (i) and, in (ii) and (iii), leave the seed investor with a smaller stake bought at a higher threshold.

Part (iii) holds J fixed and is therefore the price channel alone; the cash channel of Proposition 8 and the pre-funding channel of Proposition 14 move J itself, and the amount with it.

Two readings follow. The first is that the pre-seed investor is the only party that loses in every regime. Its stake is below the benchmark's throughout, and the mirror image of that loss is the row above it: the valuation at which it invests is above the benchmark's throughout, by the factor $\rho_p^{\text{bench}}/\rho_p^*$, and by most where the amount is smallest. Under the clause, that valuation is the price of handing m to the accelerator out of the same block.

The second reading is the one the regime labels conceal. Regime (i)—the regime in which the threshold is still $\pi(J)$, the seed investor's stake still $J/\pi(J)$ and the same projects still financed—is the regime in which the pre-seed stake is at its *lowest*. What regime (i) holds fixed is the threshold and the projects behind it, and it moves the capitalization table underneath them: the round survives the clause untouched precisely because the pre-seed investor absorbs it whole. Moving up through the regimes shifts part of that burden onto the seed investor, which pays it as a higher threshold; the pre-seed investor recovers stake in the same order, and the projects between π_1 and π_2 are what the transfer costs. The accelerator's own row is ordered against that: its stake is largest where the MFN SAFE converts inside the pre-seed block, at a price below the round, and smallest where it converts at the round. At a given residual cost, the instrument is worth most against the smallest amount.

4.8 What the clause does to payoffs

Sections 4.5–4.7 compare capitalization tables. Run on the payoffs (1) those tables generate, the comparison signs two of the three claimants and locates the one place where all three are pinned. Throughout, the benchmark is the contract (σ_a, ρ_a) of Section 3 and the reform is the same headline share, $\rho_a^0 = \rho_a$, together with the tranche

m ; both are read at the same shock $l > \sigma_a + m$, so that a pre-seed round occurs in each, and superscripts m and b distinguish them. Under the clause $\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + m/P^*$ and $\sigma_a^* = \sigma_a + m$, with $P^* = \min(V^*, V_p^*)$ as in (8).

Proposition 16 (The accelerator's payoff). *At every such shock and in all three regimes,*

$$\Pi_a^m - \Pi_a^b \geq m \left[\frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} - 1 \right] \geq 0,$$

and the bracket is at least Π_p^/σ_p^* . The inequality is strict at every $\sigma_p^* < \bar{\sigma}_p^m$, and an equality only where $\sigma_p^* = \bar{\sigma}_p^m \leq T_1$.*

The bracket is what the tranche returns per unit. The clause entitles it to $\min(V, V_p)$, a price no higher than the one the pre-seed investor pays for its own block, and that investor advances σ_p^* only where $M(V^*)/V_p^* \geq 1$. Participation upstream is therefore what puts a floor under the tranche, and the floor holds in every regime because the minimum is taken over the two prices rather than named.

Proposition 17 (The pre-seed investor's payoff). *At every such shock and in all three regimes, $\Pi_p^m \leq \Pi_p^b$, with equality if and only if $\sigma_p^* > T_2$ at a budget that binds in both games.*

Equality is the case in which the investor advances its whole budget and prices the tranche into the round: $J^m + m = J^b$, the threshold is $\pi(J^b)$, and $\Pi_p^m = W(J^b) - \beta$ is the benchmark value. Everywhere else the inequality is strict.

Proposition 18 (The seed investor's payoff). *$S'(V) = -M(V)/V^2 < 0$, and at every such shock*

$$\Pi_s^m - \Pi_s^b = \underbrace{(J^m - J^b) S(V^*)}_{\leq 0} + \underbrace{J^b [S(V^*) - S(\pi(J^b))]}_{\geq 0}.$$

Both terms vanish where the pre-seed investor advances the shock and no more. The second vanishes where $\sigma_p^ > T_2$ at a budget that binds in both games, leaving $-m S(V^*)$. Elsewhere the sum carries no sign.*

The seed investor funds less and clears a lower bar, and the two move its payoff in opposite directions. This is the same indeterminacy as in Section 4.7, read on a payoff rather than on a threshold: the pre-funding the clause induces lowers J , and Π_s is proportional to J at a rate that rises as the bar falls.

Corollary 4 (The constrained band). *Where the pre-seed investor advances the shock and no more, $\sigma_p^* \leq T_1$ and*

$$\Pi_s^m = \Pi_s^b, \quad \Pi_a^m - \Pi_a^b = -(\Pi_p^m - \Pi_p^b) = \frac{m}{\sigma_p^b} \Pi_p^b.$$

That band is the one Corollary 2(i) leaves untouched, and the corollary says what happens inside it. The seed investor funds I at $I/\pi(I)$ and finances the same projects; the block $W(I)$ is the same object in both games, and the accelerator takes the fraction m/σ_p^b of it, at the rate of return the benchmark's pre-seed investor was earning. Where the investor pre-funds instead, the two magnitudes stop matching and the seed investor stops being a bystander.

The three propositions above are read at a shock large enough that both games hold a pre-seed round. The set of financed projects is worth reading across the whole shock space, because that is where the clause's two channels separate. Below $\sigma_a + m$ the tranche is cash, and it removes a round the benchmark holds; above it the tranche is a price, and the pre-seed investor answers it with an amount.

Proposition 19 (The set of financed projects). *Compare the games at the same shock, each at its own equilibrium, and write $\pi_0^m := (I + m)/(1 - \rho_a)$ for the threshold the clause leaves when it covers the shock on its own.*

- (a) *On $l \leq \sigma_a$ neither game holds a pre-seed round, and the threshold is π_0 in the benchmark against $\pi_0^m = (1 + m/I)\pi_0$ under the clause. Strictly fewer projects are financed, in the same proportion at every such shock.*
- (b) *On $l > \sigma_a + m$ both games hold one, and $V^* \leq \pi(J^b)$: weakly more projects are financed. Equality holds where both investors advance the shock and no more, and where the two amounts coincide at a level above T_2 ; the inequality is strict elsewhere.*
- (c) *On $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + m$ the clause removes the round the benchmark holds, and the comparison is π_0^m against $\pi(J^b)$. It carries no sign. More projects are financed where the benchmark investor advances the shock and no more and $T_1 > 0$ at $J = I$, fewer where it pre-funds far enough that $J^b < J_0^m$, the residual cost the threshold equation associates with π_0^m .*

Part (b) is the one that does not survive being stated at a fixed round. Corollary 2 holds J and the amount fixed and finds the threshold weakly higher under the clause; here the amount is the pre-seed investor's own answer to the clause, and Corollary 3 makes that answer weakly larger. The larger amount carries $J + m$ below the benchmark's J , and the threshold with it, by at least what the pricing regimes add. The clause destroys financing states at a given round and creates them at a given shock, and it is the second comparison a firm faces.

Part (a) is the model's reference case. Where the shock is covered without a pre-seed round, the threshold does not depend on l , and every financed firm holds the same contract at the same price whatever its own π : the allocation is uniform because no stage separates the firms. That is the allocation a pooling contract implements when an informed intermediary faces uninformed capital (Dossou and Fleckinger, 2026), reached here for a different reason—not because the accelerator declines to separate,

but because the round that would price firms apart does not occur. The liquidity shock is what puts an interim price into the sequence, and everything this section establishes is what that price adds to the pool.

5 Measuring the quantity that decides the sign

Section 4 does not sign the reform, and that is a result rather than a gap. The accelerator gains, the intermediate investor loses, and the set of projects financed moves in a direction that depends on where the intermediate investor sits. Bridging the shock and no more leaves the financing threshold at the benchmark’s (Corollary 2(i)); pre-funding the round carries the clause into it and raises the threshold; and Corollary 3 shows the clause itself pushes toward the second. What the model delivers is not a verdict but a sufficient statistic for one: how much intermediate investors pre-fund, relative to the round they bridge to.

That quantity is observable. This section estimates the model on the cohorts admitted before Y Combinator’s January 2022 reform, reads the pre-funding ratio off the estimates, and runs the reform through the fitted equilibrium. Three results follow. The population sits in the exact-funding corner, so the adverse threshold regimes of Corollary 2(ii)–(iii) are not reached and the price channel is silent. What remains is the participation channel, which lowers seed graduation by half a percentage point against a third of a point gained from the cash. And the net, -0.13 percentage points, is two orders of magnitude below the resolution of any design this population supports—which is the quantitative content of the remark in Section 6 that a null result on graduation is uninformative about the clause.

The exercise is a calibration, not an identification strategy. It does not ask whether the change of terms caused a change in outcomes; Section 5.5 explains why no design on this population answers that. It asks what the model says the clause does, once the primitives are those that reproduce financing before the clause existed.

5.1 Data and sample

The sample is built from Crunchbase, which records funding rounds, investor participation and outcomes for the universe of venture-backed companies. Accelerator cohorts are identified by the accelerator’s participation in a company’s first recorded round; Y Combinator companies match at 88.4% and Techstars companies at 97.5%.

Each company is observed over a fixed window of twenty-four months from its batch date, and cohorts without twenty-four months of hindsight are dropped. Within that window a company either raises an intermediate round—any non-priced round between the accelerator round and the first priced round, which the model calls the pre-seed round—or does not, and either reaches a priced round or does not. This

gives 962 Y Combinator companies in the pre-reform cohorts (2019-H1 through 2021-H2) and 1,105 after, with 715 and 415 Techstars companies over the same calendar windows.

Three features of the source govern what can be estimated. Each closes off an exercise a reader would otherwise expect, and the first closes off a prediction of this paper.

Prediction five is not testable on this source. The price ratio that Proposition 9 makes the regime-sorting observable requires both the pre-seed and the priced valuation of the same company. The post-money valuation field is populated for 1.5 to 1.8% of Y Combinator intermediate rounds and 6 to 10% of its priced rounds; companies with *both* number one at Y Combinator and one at Techstars in the entire panel. This is the absence of a variable rather than a shortage of power, and no sample size fixes it. The regime must therefore be identified by the amount—prediction two—rather than by the price, which is what the rest of this section does. It also means the scale of the success payoff cannot be recovered from observed valuations and is calibrated outside the model, from realized exits.

Interim amounts are not comparable across the reform. The share of intermediate rounds with a recorded amount falls from 54.0% to 35.7% at Y Combinator across the reform while it rises from 55.1% to 59.1% at Techstars. Any moment built on post-reform Y Combinator interim *amounts* is contaminated by the selection of which rounds get reported. The estimation therefore uses pre-reform amounts, where coverage is stable, and confronts the post-reform period only on the two margins measured on the full sample—whether a company bridges, and whether it reaches a priced round. Prediction three, that pre-seed rounds get larger, is the one the model signs unambiguously and the one this source cannot evaluate.

The accelerator’s amount is measured, not assumed. The standard Y Combinator deal is not \$125,000 throughout the pre-period. Measured company by company and aggregated by batch, the modal entry amount is \$150,000 in 2019 and the first half of 2020, \$125,000 from 2020-H2 to 2021-H2, and \$500,000 from 2022, with 97% of the January 2022 batch at the new amount. The reform therefore takes effect with the batch admitted in January, not with the summer batch, and σ_a enters the estimation as a cohort-specific measured quantity rather than a constant.

5.2 Moments and identification

The model is estimated by simulated method of moments on the pre-reform Y Combinator cohorts. A simulated company draws a quality π from F , a liquidity shock l from G with an atom at zero of mass p_0 , and an investment cost I ; it is then

run through the equilibrium of Section 3, which determines whether an intermediate round occurs, what amount it carries, whether the company reaches a priced round, and what that round costs. F is Beta, G and I are lognormal, and the exit scale X is calibrated outside the model.

Eleven moments enter the criterion (Table 4), and they are of three kinds. The participation rates $M1$ and $M3$ are measured on all 962 companies and carry the information about where the thresholds sit. The amount moments $M2$ and $M4$ are measured on the 162 and 200 companies with recorded amounts and carry the information about the scale of shocks and of rounds. The ratio $M5$ —the interim amount over the priced round that follows it—is the proxy for Δ/I of prediction two, measured on 26 companies, and it is the moment that locates the corner of Proposition 3. Standard errors are firm-level bootstrap.

	Moment	Observed	Simulated	Gap (s.e.)
$M1$	Pr(intermediate round)	0.312	0.315	0.23
$M2$	Interim amount, q_{25} (\$M)	1.74	1.67	−0.42
	median	2.50	2.53	0.23
	q_{75}	3.87	3.71	−0.72
$M3a$	Pr(priced bridge)	0.167	0.218	2.49
$M3b$	Pr(priced no bridge)	0.184	0.178	−0.44
$M4$	Priced round, q_{25} (\$M)	10.0	10.1	0.18
	median	13.1	14.6	1.23
	q_{75}	20.0	21.0	0.65
$M5$	Median σ_p/J	0.205	0.215	0.36
$M7$	Median priced valuation (\$M)	87.5	23.0	−4.57

Table 4: The eleven moments, their pre-reform Y Combinator values, and the fit of the estimated model; the last column is the gap in bootstrap standard errors. $M7$ is the one moment the model does not match, and it is the valuation moment—measured on the 6–10% of priced rounds that disclose one. The model is not asked to reproduce the valuation of the disclosing subset, and the mismatch is the selection documented in Section 5.1 rather than a failure of the equilibrium.

One restriction can be read off $M1$ before any estimation, and it disciplines what follows. In the model $\text{Pr}(\text{bridge})$ is not a tail but the mass of a window, $G(\sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p) - G(\sigma_a)$: below σ_a the accelerator’s amount absorbs the shock, above $\sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$ no investor will advance it and the company is liquidated (Proposition 5). The cash channel slides that window right by \$375,000 without changing its width, since $\bar{\sigma}_p$ depends on (ρ_a, I, F) alone, none of which the reform touches. What the window loses at its lower edge is therefore bounded by the mass of shocks between the old and the new amount—at most the share of observed interim rounds below \$375,000, which is 3.1%. Three per cent of 31.2 points is under one percentage point, before netting what the window regains at its upper edge. The observed fall in $\text{Pr}(\text{bridge})$ is

19.5 points. *The cash channel cannot produce it*, and this follows from the coverage of G alone, independently of every parameter estimated below.

5.3 Estimates, and the corner

Table 5 reports four nested specifications, differing in what the model is allowed to charge beyond the investment itself.

		Param.	Criterion	d.f.	p
A	$c_E = 0$, no entry cost	7	35.31	4	$4 \cdot 10^{-7}$
B	$c_E = 0$, investor budget and entry cost	9	56.10	2	$7 \cdot 10^{-13}$
C	c_E free (<i>the model of Sections 2–4</i>)	8	2.20	3	0.53
D	c_E free, budget and entry cost	10	4.20	1	0.04

Table 5: Nested specifications on the pre-reform Y Combinator cohorts. C is the model as written, in which I is the investment the project requires together with what the entrepreneur must be left to run it, so c_E is a component of I rather than an addition to the model; A is the restriction $c_E = 0$, which the model nowhere imposes. B and D add a binding budget for the pre-seed investor and a fixed cost of entering the priced round. Neither improves on C.

Specification C is not rejected: a criterion of 2.20 on three over-identifying restrictions gives $p \approx 0.53$, and the largest gap in Table 4, setting the valuation moment aside, is 2.49 standard errors. The comparison with A is the informative one. Imposing $c_E = 0$ raises the criterion from 2.20 to 35.31: the model is then asked to generate the observed distance between interim amounts and priced rounds out of the investment cost alone, and cannot. What the entrepreneur must be left to run the company is a large share of what the seed round finances, estimated at $\hat{c}_E = 0.192$ with an entrepreneurial share $\hat{\rho}_E = 0.565$.

		Estimate	95% interval
$\mathbb{E}(\pi)$	Mean project quality	0.240	[0.219, 0.262]
p_0	Mass of companies with no interim need	0.378	[0.320, 0.438]
$\text{median}(l)$	Median shock, conditional on need	\$4.29M	[\$3.40M, \$5.08M]
c_E	Entrepreneur’s cost component of I	0.192	[0.165, 0.219]
ρ_E	Entrepreneur’s equilibrium share	0.565	[0.545, 0.589]

Table 6: Estimated primitives, specification C, pre-reform Y Combinator cohorts. Intervals are firm-level bootstrap, 500 replications, re-estimating on each draw.

The median shock of \$4.29M is large relative to what “bridge” suggests, and should be read for what l is in this model: not a few months of runway but the entire financing

need preceding the priced round, without which the project does not reach that round at all. For a company taking two to three years to reach a Series A, several million dollars is the right order of magnitude.

The corner. The median interim amount is 0.21 of the round that follows it in the data and 0.22 in the estimated model. By prediction two this is the exact-funding corner: intermediate investors cover the shock and do not pre-fund the round. The consequence is the one the theory sets up. By Proposition 10 a participating investor on that branch reaches the first regime alone, so Corollary 2(i) applies and the financing threshold is the benchmark’s; the adverse regimes (ii) and (iii) are not reached by any company in the estimated population. Corollary 3 is live in the sense that the clause does push toward pre-funding, but the budgets here are far from carrying anyone across T_1 .

5.4 What the reform does

The counterfactual holds the estimated primitives fixed and changes only the contract: σ_a rises from its measured pre-reform value to \$500,000, and the accelerator’s claim acquires the MFN provision with $m = \$375,000$. Everything else is a consequence of the equilibrium.

Effect on...	Cash channel	Clause	Total
Pr(priced round), pp	+0.342	−0.527	−0.127
95% interval	[0.306, 0.495]	[−0.605, −0.415]	[−0.168, −0.015]
Pr(intermediate round), pp	+2.03	−2.36	−0.327
95% interval		[−3.13, −1.77]	[−0.775, −0.107]

Table 7: The reform run through the estimated model, in percentage points, switching on the cash increase and the clause separately and then jointly. Intervals are the bootstrap of Table 6 propagated through the counterfactual.

The price channel is silent, and not by assumption. In all 500 bootstrap draws the equilibrium sits in the first regime of Proposition 9: the intermediate investor absorbs the clause in its own valuation and the threshold is the one that would have prevailed without it. Corollary 2(i) is not a knife-edge case the estimation happens to select—it is where the estimated primitives put the entire confidence region. Carrying the clause into the round would take an amount of the order of the company’s value, and nothing in the estimated distribution approaches it.

What is left is participation, and it dominates the cash. The extra cash raises the probability of a priced round by 0.34 points by moving both boundaries of Proposition 5 rightwards. Against it, Proposition 10 lowers the cap on the amount from $W(J)$ to $W(J) - m$: the clause removes from the intermediate investor exactly m of what it was willing to advance, and companies whose residual need sits in that band lose their investor altogether. That costs 0.53 points. This is the channel the threshold analysis does not see—Corollary 2 holds the amount fixed, and here the amount is what moves—and on these estimates it is the larger of the two.

The net is -0.13 points. The comparison that Section 6 says signs the sum—whether the cash the accelerator adds covers what the clause withdraws from the intermediate investor’s capacity—comes out negative for this population, and negative throughout the confidence interval.

No clause of this size could have moved the aggregate. Seed graduation fell 13.8 percentage points across the reform. Inverting the model for the m that would deliver that fall through the clause alone gives \$27.6M, or 73.7 times the actual \$375,000; on the interim margin the same calculation gives \$2.92M, or 7.8 times. This uses no estimate of the reform’s effect and does not depend on the calibration of the exit scale. It asks what the model would need the clause to be, and the answer is off by one to two orders of magnitude on both margins.

Appendix B takes the complementary step and asks what displacement of the primitives does reproduce the post-reform period. The reform accounts for about one per cent of the movement.

5.5 Why no reduced-form design recovers this

Section 6 observes that a reform doing two things at once can leave the graduation rate where it was, which makes a null result on graduation uninformative. The estimates make that concrete, and in a stronger form: on this population the effect is not merely offset, it is unresolvable.

The natural design compares Y Combinator cohorts around January 2022 against an accelerator that did not change its terms, and Techstars is the obvious control, its standard deal stable at \$120,000 from 2019 through 2023. We ran it. It does not identify the reform’s effect, and the reason is not a shortage of data.

The joint test of pre-treatment parallel trends is rejected for every outcome: a Wald statistic of 635 on the probability of a priced round within twenty-four months, 211 at thirty-six months, 16.3 on the log interim amount, each with p indistinguishable from zero. The event study explains the rejection. Against a 2021-H2 reference, the Y Combinator–Techstars graduation gap runs +11.6, +21.4, +16.9, +8.7, 0 across the pre-reform cohorts and +4.2, +2.8, +5.1 across the reform: it declines continuously

from 2020, does not break at the treatment, and leaves the treated cohorts *above* the reference. A difference-in-differences coefficient of -5.7 points is the average of a high pre-period against a low post-period. On the interim margin the break falls in 2022-H1, one cohort *before* treatment, which dates it to the first-quarter venture correction.

One fact makes the point without estimation: Y Combinator seed graduation falls from 0.282 to 0.126 between 2020-H2 and 2021-H2—half the total decline, entirely inside the control period, a year before the clause existed.

The calibration explains this rather than excusing it. A design on two thousand companies resolves effects of the order of a percentage point at best, and the model puts the clause at 0.13. The design was not underpowered by accident and no number of additional cohorts would repair it, because the estimand sits two orders of magnitude below the resolution of the population. This is the practical content of Corollary 2(i): a clause that redistributes equity at a fixed conversion base, on a population that does not pre-fund, does not move financing outcomes enough to appear in graduation rates. Where the reform is visible is on the amount—prediction three, which this source cannot measure but a source with better coverage of interim rounds could.

6 Discussion

6.1 What a valuation measures

Every price here is an equilibrium object, and the three rounds build theirs out of different material. Setting them side by side is worth doing on its own, because the number companies are ranked by in practice is the one the model constructs last. Gornall and Strebulaev (2020) measure how far that number stands above the fair value of a company by pricing each class of its table separately; the question here is what the equilibrium puts into it.

The round price is a boundary in the distribution of quality. By Proposition 1 the seed investor names $V = J/(1 - \rho_a - \rho_p)$ and finances the projects above $\pi_{\min} = V$; by Proposition 9 the same identity holds in each of the three regimes the clause opens. That investor moves after π is revealed, so it prices in full knowledge of what it is buying, and it names one V for every company it finances. What the price locates is the success probability of the marginal financed project, expressed in the units of the payoff: a statement about the set the round selects, with every company in that set carrying the price of its weakest member.

Two quantities move that boundary. The threshold rises with the residual investment cost J the round must still clear, and with the block $\rho_a + \rho_p$ converting ahead of it. A company carrying a large sunk cost into a crowded capitalization table prices high for those two reasons, and by $\pi_{\min} = V$ the projects it must beat in order to be financed

are better in the same measure. A high round price and a narrow financed set are one fact read twice.

The interim price carries the shock. By Corollary 1 the pre-seed investor’s equilibrium share is pinned by (ρ_a, I, F) alone, so at exact funding its valuation scales one-for-one with the residual need: the investor takes the share it wants, and the price is the arithmetic that converts an amount into that share. Two companies alike in π and hit by different shocks price apart in proportion to the shocks, having sold the same stake, at the same threshold, with the same probability of reaching the round. What the interim valuation measures is the size of the need that had to be covered.

Under the clause it carries the transfer as well. By Corollary 2(i) an investor absorbing the MFN SAFE raises its valuation by exactly the amount the clause converts, and by Proposition 15(iii) that valuation sits strictly above its benchmark value in all three regimes—among them the two in which the threshold rises and financing states are destroyed. Across that comparison, a higher interim valuation is a reading of the equity handed to the accelerator.

Three quantities therefore move the prices this environment generates: the residual cost of the round, the block of claims converting ahead of it, and the size of the interim shock. An observer ranking companies by valuation ranks them by capital intensity and capitalization structure, and that ranking is informative about the financing chain behind it—which is what the predictions below exploit, the price ratio sorting the conversion regimes and the amount sorting the corner. Carried into a comparison of prospects, the same number reverses the ordering it appears to give: an industry whose sunk cost I stands orders of magnitude above the software rounds these instruments were written for posts the highest round prices at any given distribution of quality, and finances the narrowest set of projects while it does so.

6.2 Empirical implications

The model delivers five predictions that do not require knowing the primitives. Table 8 collects them.

Valuations move with amounts, stakes do not. By Corollary 1, the pre-seed investor’s equilibrium share is pinned down by (ρ_a, I, F) alone. Across companies from the same cohort facing different liquidity shocks, the amount raised at the pre-seed stage and the valuation at which it is raised should move together one-for-one, while pre-seed ownership stakes should be flat in the amount. This is a within-cohort prediction and therefore does not require comparing accelerators to one another. It is also the prediction that identifies the regime: it holds in the exact-funding corner and fails once the investor pre-funds, since the pre-funded part moves the threshold and hence the share.

The amount reveals the corner. By Proposition 3, an investor that merely covers a shock advances an amount that is small relative to the round that follows it, while an investor that pre-funds advances one of the order of the round itself. The ratio of the interim amount to the subsequent priced round is therefore a direct proxy for Δ/I , and reading it is the cheapest available test of which corner early-stage financing sits in—without estimating a single primitive. The same ratio predicts the cross-sectional pattern of thresholds: flat in the need where amounts are small, rising in the need where they are budget-constrained.

Pre-seed rounds get larger. By Proposition 14, the MFN SAFE removes a fixed sum from the pre-seed investor’s block and therefore dilutes small amounts proportionally more than large ones, which strengthens the incentive to pre-fund. Post-2022 pre-seed rounds should thus be larger, and larger by more than the mechanical substitution the cash channel produces—the accelerator’s extra cash reduces the residual need, which on its own would make interim amounts *smaller*. This is the one prediction of the reform whose sign the model does not leave ambiguous, and the two forces are separable in data: the cash channel shifts the need, the clause shifts the amount conditional on the need.

Seed success falls wherever the clause is not paid for in cash. The reform moves seed success through three channels, and only one of them is the price.

The price channel is silent on the constrained branch. Where the investor advances the shock and no more, no participating investor reaches T_1 (Proposition 10): it absorbs the clause in its own valuation, the threshold is the one that would have prevailed without the clause (Corollary 2(i)), and not one financing state is destroyed among the companies it finances. Past T_1 the channel turns adverse, and beyond T_2 it settles at $\pi(J + m)$.

The participation channel is not silent anywhere. By Proposition 10 the cap on the amount falls to $W(J) - m$ on that same branch: the clause takes from the investor exactly m of what it was willing to advance. Companies whose residual need sits in that band lose their investor, and a company without an investor does not reach the round at all. This is a loss of financing states that the previous paragraph does not see, because Corollary 2 holds the amount fixed and asks what the clause does to the threshold; here the amount is what the clause changes. The two readings are consistent and the second is the one that binds where the first says nothing.

The cash channel is the only one pushing up. It moves both boundaries of Proposition 5 rightwards (Proposition 8), which takes companies out of liquidation as well as out of the pre-seed region. Its size is the accelerator’s extra cash and nothing else.

The three do not cancel by construction, and their sum is signed by one comparison: whether the cash the accelerator adds covers what the clause withdraws from the

pre-seed investor’s capacity. An accelerator that hands over m in a clause and adds no cash lowers seed success; one that adds enough cash raises it. Nothing about the drafting of the clause decides this, and a reform that does both at once can leave the graduation rate where it was—which is what makes a null result on graduation uninformative about whether the clause did anything.

One population is left out of that arithmetic and should not be. A company that needs no pre-seed round has no investor to absorb the clause, so the MFN SAFE converts at the price of the priced round: it joins the block ahead of the seed investor, and the threshold such a company faces rises by $m/(1 - \rho_a^0)$. The clause is therefore never purely redistributive across the whole population, however constrained the investors are.

The price ratio sorts the regimes. The predictions above are silent on which regime a given company sits in, and Proposition 9 says that one observable settles it: the pre-seed valuation divided by the valuation of the round that follows. Below one, the clause converts inside the pre-seed block and the threshold holds; at one, the three claims convert on a single base; above one, the clause has been pushed into the round. Because $\pi_{\min}^*$ rises along that order, the ratio rises exactly where the seed investor’s stake J/V and the probability of a seed round fall, and none of the three quantities requires knowing J or the primitives. This is what turns the branch of the previous prediction from a latent type into a measured one: under the reform, seed-graduation rates should be flat among companies whose pre-seed round priced below the seed round and lower among those priced at or above it. What it demands of data is a price per share at both rounds for the same company, which rules out sources recording amounts alone.

6.3 What the clause achieves, and where

What the clause is designed to do and what it does to financing are two different things, and the model separates them cleanly.

The distributive objective is met in every regime. Whatever price the pre-seed investor sets, the MFN SAFE converts on the more favourable of the two bases, so the accelerator is never left holding worse terms than the investor that came after it. That is what the clause was written for, and it works.

The financing effect splits at $J^\dagger$. On the constrained branch, where the investor advances the shock and no more, no participating investor reaches T_1 (Proposition 10): the investor absorbs the clause in its own price, raising its valuation by exactly the MFN SAFE, and the financing threshold is the one that would have prevailed without the clause. The accelerator gains equity, the pre-seed investor gives up precisely that equity, and no project that would otherwise have been financed fails to be. On the pre-funding branch, amounts past T_1 become available and the threshold rises—to $\hat{V}_p$

Prediction	Source	What to measure	What the model says
Amounts move, stakes do not	Cor. 1	Pre-seed stake against the amount raised, within an accelerator cohort	Stake flat in the amount, valuation moving one-for-one with it; the pattern breaks once the investor pre-funds, which is what makes it identify the regime
The amount reveals the corner	Prop. 3	Interim amount over the next priced round, a proxy for Δ/I	Small ratio: exact funding, thresholds flat in the need. Ratio of the order of the round: pre-funding, thresholds rising in it
Pre-seed rounds get larger	Prop. 14	Amount size before and after January 2022	Up, and by more than the cash channel alone implies—that channel cuts the residual need and so pushes amounts the other way
Seed success, three channels	Props. 8, 10, 2	Seed-graduation rates of comparable cohorts around January 2022	Down through participation, the cap falling to $W(J) - m$, and through the companies with no pre-seed round, whose threshold rises by $m/(1 - \rho_a^0)$; up through the cash the accelerator adds. The price channel is silent below T_1 and adverse above it
The price ratio sorts the regimes	Prop. 9	Pre-seed valuation over the valuation of the next round, company by company	Below one: clause absorbed, threshold held. At one: one conversion base. Above one: clause in the round, seed stake and graduation both lower

Table 8: The five predictions of Section 6, their source in the model, and what each requires from data. None needs the primitives (F, G, m) to be known: every entry is a within-cohort comparison, a cross-sectional shape, or a before-and-after on the January 2022 change of terms. The first two identify which corner of Proposition 3 early-stage financing sits in; the next two are the reform’s effects, on amounts and on seed success; the last reads off which pricing regime a company is in, and so tells the fourth which companies to compare.

on the middle range, to $\pi(J + m)$ beyond T_2 —so financing states are destroyed.

What decides is the size of the amount, not the drafting of the clause. The same instrument leaves the round untouched in the hands of an investor bridging a shock, and costs it projects in the hands of one pre-funding a round. Incidence is therefore a property of balance sheets, and a regulator or an accelerator revising the clause changes nothing about which of the two applies.

6.4 The three arguments for the reform

Three arguments are made for clauses of this kind. The analysis supports one with a qualification, supports the second for a different reason than the one given, and cannot speak to the third.

That the reform reduces fundraising pressure: supported, on one branch. The cash channel mechanically enlarges the set of firms that never need an interim round. Conditional on needing one, an investor in the first regime raises the valuation by exactly the MFN SAFE while its own stake falls to $\rho_p^* \sigma_p / (\sigma_p + m)$ —less dilution at a higher price, which is what the argument asserted, and the repricing it implicitly assumes is what Corollary 2(i) delivers. Past T_1 the argument fails: the investor prices at or above the round and the firm is diluted more, not less.

That it raises seed success: supported only through the cash. The argument credits the price guarantee. The price channel in fact contributes nothing where the clause converts inside the pre-seed block, and works against seed success where it reaches the round; and the clause withdraws m from what the pre-seed investor will advance, which costs financing states on every branch. What raises seed success is the cash the accelerator commits (Propositions 8 and 14)—and those larger amounts are also what can carry an investor past $J^\dagger$. The reform helps on a margin it did not advertise, and the same margin can turn against it.

That it attracts more founders: outside the model. The environment closes with the seed investor extracting the residual, so the entrepreneur’s ex-ante value is zero before and after the reform and the margin along which applicants would be drawn does not exist here. Evaluating that claim requires a closure with positive founder rents—a competitive seed stage, for instance—under which the founder’s ex-ante value would inherit the same regime structure.

6.5 Limitations

Six modelling choices bound the analysis.

The pre-seed investor is a monopolist. Under competition its profit is driven to zero and its valuation is pinned at the participation frontier $M(\pi_{\min}) = V_p$ rather than by

the first-order condition. The three branches of the price survive that change, since they come from the capitalization table and not from the objective; which branch a competitive investor lands on need not be the one a monopolist picks, and we have not solved for it. What we can say is that competition does not dissolve the pre-funding motive: with zero profit the terms sit on the participation frontier, but the firm still prefers the offer carrying the lowest threshold, which is the most pre-funded one, so pre-funding survives and its surplus accrues to the founder instead.

The seed investor extracts the residual equity. That is what closes the model at the last stage, and it is also what makes the founder margin unavailable—the entrepreneur’s ex-ante value is zero whatever the contract upstream, which is why the third argument for the reform cannot be evaluated here.

The entrepreneur exerts no effort, at any stage. The probability of success π is drawn and revealed, not produced. Shares therefore carry no incentive role, and dilution costs the firm only through the financing constraint it tightens, never through the effort it discourages—which is what lets the capitalization table be read as pure accounting, and what sets the model apart from the security-design tradition that runs from Neher (1999) to Repullo and Suarez (2004), where the split of returns is the object precisely because it moves effort. The omission is tied to the previous one: with the seed investor extracting the residual, the entrepreneur holds nothing in equilibrium, so an effort decision would have nothing to respond to. Restoring effort therefore means restoring a founder stake, and the two extensions have to be made together. What would come of it is not obvious in either direction, and the regimes divide again: in regime (i) the clause moves equity between the two investors and leaves the rest of the table untouched, so an effort margin would register nothing; in (ii) and (iii) the seed stake moves, and it would.

Effort at more than one date would also carry the dilution backwards. Write $\pi = \pi(e_1, e_2)$ for effort supplied before and after the shock, and suppose the two are complements, $\pi_{12} > 0$ —an entrepreneur who has already worked finds the next round of work cheaper. The interim round dilutes between the two dates, so it lowers e_2 ; by complementarity that lowers the return to e_1 , and e_1 falls *in anticipation*, before any dilution has occurred. The cost of an interim round would then exceed what the static calculation shows and part of it would be borne upstream, which is a channel this model cannot express at all. A second loop points the same way: a higher threshold makes financing less likely, which lowers the return to effort, which lowers π and makes the threshold bind harder still. Both are amplification rather than addition, and both would weigh on regimes (ii) and (iii) alone.

No investor exerts effort either. Accelerators sell training, mentorship and investor networking alongside their capital (Zeisberger et al., 2017; Gonzalez-Urbe and Leatherbee, 2018), and pre-seed investors arriving after the shock know the company and can act on it; neither activity appears here, where investors supply cash and nothing else. This omission does not run into the closure the way the entrepreneur’s does—investors hold strictly positive stakes in all three regimes—and it bears directly on the result.

The clause moves equity from the pre-seed investor to the accelerator, that is from the party still in contact with the company to one whose program has ended. If equity is what motivates support, the transfer runs the wrong way, and it does so precisely in regime (i), where the model finds the clause purely redistributive. Whether that channel is large enough to move the threshold in regime (i) is an open question, and answering it requires a model in which what investors do, and not only what they pay, enters the project’s prospects.

The liquidity shock is exogenous. A firm anticipating the clause might adjust its burn rate, which would make l a choice variable and the regimes endogenous to the contract itself.

The budget β is a parameter rather than a choice, and the bound $\beta \leq I$ that defines the investor as intermediate is imposed rather than derived. Endogenizing it turns that investor into a fund choosing its size before observing deal flow, and the natural discipline is that a fund large enough to pre-empt every round is a seed fund and prices its capital accordingly—which is to say that the boundary between investor tiers, taken as given here, is itself an equilibrium object. That is the extension we would rank first, and for a reason the analysis makes precise: the budget decides how far the investor can pre-fund, hence which side of $J^\dagger$ the residual cost falls on, hence whether the clause stays inside the pre-seed block or reaches the round. Deriving it rather than assuming it would say which investors the clause helps and which it constrains, instead of taking their identities as data.

Each of these extensions preserves the architecture—a threshold, a participation cap, and the three-regime structure of the clause—while changing who captures the surplus.

7 Conclusion

A most-favored-nation clause in an accelerator’s contract is written to protect the accelerator against terms granted to later investors, and it does so mechanically. Its effect on financing, however, runs through an agent it does not bind: the pre-seed investor, who decides by its own pricing whether the clause converts inside its block or inside the priced round. That investor holds two margins, an amount and a price, and they are not independent. Cash advanced beyond the interim shock survives to the round and lightens what the seed investor must contribute, so pre-funding buys a lower financing threshold at a marginal value that *rises* as the round is pre-funded. The amount is therefore a corner, and which corner is a conclusion rather than an assumption.

The price margin resolves into three regimes, separated by two cutoffs in the amount. Below the first, the investor prices low and absorbs the clause: it raises its valuation by exactly the amount the clause converts, hands that equity to the accelerator, and

leaves the financing threshold where the benchmark put it—the clause redistributes and does not ration. Above the second, it prices high and passes the clause to the seed investor, who must clear $J+m$ out of the same capitalization table; the threshold rises from $\pi(J)$ to $\pi(J+m)$ and financing states are destroyed. Between them the two prices bunch and the clause converts at the round. The contrast between the three is one of rationing; the redistribution is common to all of them, the pre-seed stake sitting strictly below its benchmark value at a given amount and the valuation strictly above. A higher interim valuation is what the clause produces in every state of the world.

Which regimes an investor can reach is settled by one comparison, and this is the paper’s sharpest statement. Participation caps the amount, and where that cap falls depends on whether the cost the investor leaves the seed round lies above or below $J^\dagger$, the point at which pre-funding stops paying. An investor that merely bridges the shock is on the far side of the pivot and never leaves the first regime, where the threshold is the benchmark’s. One that pre-funds heavily crosses the pivot and opens the other two. The same cash that lowers the financing bar through J is what opens the regimes that raise it: the clause leaves the threshold alone exactly where pre-funding does not pay, and raises it exactly where it does. What decides the incidence is not the drafting of the clause but the size of the amount—and therefore the balance sheet behind it.

The clause also has an unambiguous effect on that amount. Because it removes a fixed sum from a block whose size the investor chooses, it dilutes a small amount far more than a large one, and pushes the investor toward advancing larger ones. Larger amounts are the pre-funding that lowers the threshold; they are also what carries an investor across the pivot. The reform’s two effects therefore run in opposite directions along the same margin, and the model does not sign their sum.

Finally, the value of the protection depends on who holds it. The accelerator commits at admission, on terms it can no longer revise, and for it a clause carrying no base of its own is pure gain: it recovers a price it could never have negotiated. The pre-seed investor arrives after the shock and *sets* a price; for it the same rule replaces a decision it was taking optimally with a mechanical outcome, and it is weakly worse off—strictly, by Proposition 12, wherever its amounts are large enough for the substitution to bind. The rule protects an investor that cannot price and constrains one that can.

The same results say what a valuation measures here. The round is priced at the threshold it enforces, so a high price and a narrow set of financed projects are one statement, and what raises both is the sunk cost the round must clear together with the block of claims converting ahead of it. The interim round is priced at the share the investor wants, so its valuation moves with the shock it covers and, under the clause, with the equity it hands over. Each price is a reading of the chain behind it, and the paper’s sorting prediction rests on exactly that: the ratio of the two identifies the regime a company sits in. The ordering they give of companies’ prospects runs the other way, the highest prices arising where the sunk cost is largest, which is where

the fewest projects clear the bar.

The general lesson is about sequence. Protection granted at one financing stage always changes the terms of the stages that follow, because the investors at those stages adjust the terms they offer, and they adjust on every margin they hold. Whether a reform of this kind helps the companies it is meant to help therefore turns on an empirical magnitude the theory identifies but cannot supply: how much intermediate investors pre-fund. The model says where to look—the ratio of the interim amount to the round that follows it—and what the answer would mean.

For the companies Y Combinator admitted before its reform, that ratio is a fifth. They are on the far side of the pivot, their investors bridge and do not pre-fund, and the clause therefore never leaves the regime in which it redistributes without rationing. What rations is the participation cap, which the clause lowers by the sum it converts and which the reform's extra cash does not fully restore: the net movement in seed graduation is -0.13 percentage points, against the 13.8 points by which graduation actually fell over those cohorts. Reproducing that fall through the clause would take a clause seventy-four times the size of the one that was written, and the model reproduces the period only when the quality of the companies admitted and the scale of the financing they need are both allowed to move—neither of which follows from the change of terms.

The practical reading is narrow. A best-price clause is a good instrument for the party that cannot price and a constraint on the party that can, and on a population that does not pre-fund it is close to inert on whether companies get financed. Announcing such a clause as a way to improve the odds of reaching a priced round proposes an effect the mechanism does not have at this scale, and looking for that effect in graduation rates will not find it at any sample size this population offers. Where the clause acts is on the size of the round it precedes, and that is where a design should look.

References

- Admati, A. R. and Pfleiderer, P. (1994). Robust financial contracting and the role of venture capitalists. *The Journal of Finance*, 49(2):371–402.
- Bengtsson, O. and Sensoy, B. A. (2011). Investor abilities and financial contracting: Evidence from venture capital. *Journal of Financial Intermediation*, 20(4):477–502.
- Bergemann, D. and Hege, U. (2005). The financing of innovation: Learning and stopping. *RAND Journal of Economics*, 36(4):719–752.
- Besanko, D. and Lyon, T. P. (1993). Equilibrium incentives for most-favored customer clauses in an oligopolistic industry. *International Journal of Industrial Organization*, 11(3):347–367.
- Carta (2025). State of private markets: 2025 in review. Technical report, Carta. Transaction-level data on SAFE structure; the share of capped, no-discount SAFEs among all SAFEs issued rose over 2025, from roughly six in ten to roughly three in four.
- Casamatta, C. (2003). Financing and advising: Optimal financial contracts with venture capitalists. *Journal of Finance*, 58(5):2059–2085.
- Cooper, T. E. (1986). Most-favored-customer pricing and tacit collusion. *The RAND Journal of Economics*, 17(3):377–388.
- Cornelli, F. and Yosha, O. (2003). Stage financing and the role of convertible securities. *The Review of Economic Studies*, 70(1):1–32.
- Coyle, J. F. and Green, J. M. (2014). Contractual innovation in venture capital. *Hastings Law Journal*, 66(1):133–183.
- De Meza, D. and Webb, D. C. (1987). Too much investment: A problem of asymmetric information. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 102(2):281–292.
- Dossou, S. and Fleckinger, P. (2026). Pooling contracts between venture capital institutions. Working paper.
- Ewens, M., Nanda, R., and Rhodes-Kropf, M. (2018). Cost of experimentation and the evolution of venture capital. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 128(3):422–442.
- Gompers, P. A. (1995). Optimal investment, monitoring, and the staging of venture capital. *The Journal of Finance*, 50(5):1461–1489.
- Gonzalez-Uribe, J. and Leatherbee, M. (2018). The effects of business accelerators on venture performance: Evidence from start-up chile. *The Review of Financial Studies*, 31(4):1566–1603.
- Gornall, W. and Strebulaev, I. A. (2020). Squaring venture capital valuations with reality. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 135(1):120–143.

- Hallen, B. L., Cohen, S. L., and Bingham, C. B. (2020). Do accelerators work? if so, how? *Organization Science*, 31(2):378–414.
- Hellmann, T. (1998). The allocation of control rights in venture capital contracts. *The RAND Journal of Economics*, 29(1):57–76.
- Hellmann, T. and Puri, M. (2002). Venture capital and the professionalization of start-up firms: Empirical evidence. *The Journal of Finance*, 57(1):169–197.
- Hellmann, T. and Thiele, V. (2015). Friends or foes? the interrelationship between angel and venture capital markets. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 115(3):639–653.
- Hochberg, Y. V., Ljungqvist, A., and Lu, Y. (2007). Whom you know matters: Venture capital networks and investment performance. *The Journal of Finance*, 62(1):251–301.
- Jaffee, D. M. and Russell, T. (1976). Imperfect information, uncertainty, and credit rationing. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, 90(4):651–666.
- Kaplan, S. N. and Strömberg, P. (2003). Financial contracting theory meets the real world: An empirical analysis of venture capital contracts. *The Review of Economic Studies*, 70(2):281–315.
- Kaplan, S. N. and Strömberg, P. (2004). Characteristics, contracts, and actions: Evidence from venture capitalist analyses. *The Journal of Finance*, 59(5):2177–2210.
- Lerner, J. and Nanda, R. (2020). Venture capital’s role in financing innovation: What we know and how much we still need to learn. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 34(3):237–261.
- McAfee, R. P. and Schwartz, M. (1994). Opportunism in multilateral vertical contracting: Nondiscrimination, exclusivity, and uniformity. *American Economic Review*, 84(1):210–230.
- Nanda, R. and Rhodes-Kropf, M. (2017). Financing risk and innovation. *Management Science*, 63(4):901–918.
- Neher, D. V. (1999). Staged financing: An agency perspective. *The Review of Economic Studies*, 66(2):255–274.
- Repullo, R. and Suarez, J. (2004). Venture capital finance: A security design approach. *Review of Finance*, 8(1):75–108.
- Sahlman, W. A. (1990). The structure and governance of venture-capital organizations. *Journal of Financial Economics*, 27(2):473–521.
- Schmidt, K. M. (2003). Convertible securities and venture capital finance. *The Journal of Finance*, 58(3):1139–1166.

- Stiglitz, J. E. and Weiss, A. (1981). Credit rationing in markets with imperfect information. *American Economic Review*, 71(3):393–410.
- Zeisberger, C., Prahl, M., and White, B. (2017). *Mastering Private Equity*. Wiley.

A Proofs

Proof of Proposition 1

Proof. The objective is strictly increasing in the share it takes, so both constraints bind. The entrepreneur is left the smallest share that has him run a project he is financed for, $\rho_E^* = c_E/\pi_{\min}$, and the seed investor takes the rest of the table, $(J - c_E)/V = 1 - \rho_a - \rho_p - c_E/\pi_{\min}$. It finances a project when its claim covers its outlay, $\pi(J - c_E)/V \geq J - c_E$, that is $\pi \geq V$, so $\pi_{\min} = V$; substituting it into the binding table gives $\pi_{\min}(1 - \rho_a - \rho_p) = J$. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 1

Proof. Any $\sigma_p < b$ leaves the shock uncovered. The firm is then liquidated before π is revealed, the claim never converts, and the amount is sunk, for a payoff of $-\sigma_p$; this is strictly dominated by not proposing, which yields zero. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 2

Proof. Bounds. $D > 0$ because $M > 0$ on $(0, 1)$, and writing (6) as

$$\psi(\pi) = k\pi \frac{\pi^2 f(\pi)}{\pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi)} = \frac{k\pi}{1 + M(\pi)/(\pi^2 f(\pi))} \quad (9)$$

gives $0 < \psi(\pi) < k\pi < k$ at once, since $M > 0$.

Monotonicity. Using $M' = -\pi f$, so that $D' = \pi f + \pi^2 f'$,

$$\frac{\psi'(\pi) D(\pi)^2}{k} = \pi^2(3f + \pi f')D - \pi^3 f \cdot \pi(f + \pi f') = \pi^2 \left[2\pi^2 f^2 + M(3f + \pi f') \right],$$

the terms in ff' cancelling, all functions evaluated at π . Write $c := -f'(\pi)/f(\pi)$, so the bracket equals $f(2\pi^2 f + M(3 - c\pi))$ and the claim reduces to

$$2\pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi)(3 - c\pi) > 0.$$

If $c \leq 3/\pi$ the second term is non-negative and the inequality is immediate, since $f > 0$. Suppose then $c > 3/\pi$, in particular $c > 0$. Log-concavity of f in (A1) means that $\log f$ lies below its tangent at π , so $f(t) \leq f(\pi)e^{-c(t-\pi)}$ for every $t \geq \pi$, whence

$$M(\pi) = \int_{\pi}^1 t f(t) dt \leq f(\pi) \int_{\pi}^{\infty} t e^{-c(t-\pi)} dt = f(\pi) \frac{c\pi + 1}{c^2}.$$

Because $3 - c\pi < 0$, substituting this upper bound can only lower the left-hand side:

$$2\pi^2 f + M(3 - c\pi) \geq \frac{f}{c^2} \left(2c^2\pi^2 + (c\pi + 1)(3 - c\pi) \right) = \frac{f}{c^2} \left((c\pi + 1)^2 + 2 \right) > 0.$$

Hence $\psi' > 0$ on $(0, 1)$.

Limits. At the lower end, $0 < \psi(\pi) < k\pi$ gives $\psi(0^+) = 0$.

At the upper end, write $r := (1 - F)/f$ for the reciprocal of the hazard rate, non-increasing by (A1) and non-negative, so it has a limit $L \geq 0$ at 1^- . Suppose $L > 0$. Then $r \geq L$ on $(0, 1)$, so $-(\log(1 - F))' = 1/r \leq 1/L$ there, and integrating from any $\pi_0 < 1$ gives $1 - F(\pi) \geq (1 - F(\pi_0))e^{-(\pi - \pi_0)/L}$ for every $\pi < 1$. The right-hand side is bounded away from zero as $\pi \rightarrow 1^-$, contradicting $F(1^-) = 1$. Hence $L = 0$. Now $t \leq 1$ throughout $[\pi, 1]$, so $M(\pi) = \int_{\pi}^1 t f(t) dt \leq \int_{\pi}^1 f(t) dt = 1 - F(\pi)$ —the value carried by the projects above the threshold is at most their probability—and therefore

$$0 \leq \frac{M(\pi)}{\pi^2 f(\pi)} \leq \frac{r(\pi)}{\pi^2} \xrightarrow{\pi \rightarrow 1^-} 0,$$

and (9) gives $\psi(1^-) = k$.

The three claims. Being continuous and strictly increasing with limits 0 and k , ψ is a bijection from $(0, 1)$ onto $(0, k)$. Fix J in that range. Then $J = \psi(\pi)$ has the unique solution $\pi(J) = \psi^{-1}(J)$, and evaluating $\psi(\pi) < k\pi$ at $\pi = \pi(J)$ reads $J < k\pi(J)$: this is (i). Next $\varphi'_J = -D(\psi - J)/\pi^2$ has the sign of $J - \psi$, so φ_J strictly increases below $\pi(J)$ and strictly decreases above it, making the critical point the maximum: this is (ii). Finally the inverse of a strictly increasing map is strictly increasing: this is (iii). $\square$

Proof of Lemma 3

Proof. $W(J) = \max_{\pi} \varphi_J(\pi)$ with $\partial \varphi_J / \partial J = -M(\pi)/\pi$ from (3); the envelope theorem evaluates this derivative at the maximizer $\pi = \pi(J)$, giving $W'(J) = -\Lambda(J)$. Since $\sigma_p = b + \Delta$ and $J = I - \Delta$, (4) gives $\partial \Pi_p / \partial \Delta = -W'(J) - 1 = \Lambda(J) - 1$. For monotonicity, $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing by Lemma 2—and $x \mapsto M(x)/x$ is strictly decreasing, since M is positive and strictly decreasing. Hence Λ is strictly decreasing in J and strictly increasing in Δ . $\square$

Proof of Proposition 3

Proof. Two objects. Since $\Lambda(J) = M(\pi(J))/\pi(J)$, the marginal value of pre-funding crosses one where the threshold reaches the fixed point of M . Define $\bar{x}$ by $M(\bar{x}) = \bar{x}$: as $M(x) - x$ is continuous and strictly decreasing from $M(0) = \mathbb{E}(\pi) > 0$ at $x = 0$ to -1 at $x = 1$, that pivot exists and is unique in $(0, 1)$. Define $J^\dagger$ by $\pi(J^\dagger) = \bar{x}$: by Lemma 2, $\pi(\cdot)$ is a strictly increasing bijection from $(0, k)$ onto $(0, 1)$, so $J^\dagger = \psi(\bar{x})$ exists and is unique as well. Write $\Delta^\dagger := I - J^\dagger$, so that $\Lambda(J^\dagger) = 1$ by construction.

If $\Delta^\dagger \leq 0$ (i.e. $I \leq J^\dagger$), then $\Pi'_p(0) = \Lambda(I) - 1 \geq 0$ and, by convexity (Lemma 3),

$\Pi'_p \geq 0$ throughout $[0, I]$: Π_p is non-decreasing, so $\sigma_p^* = \beta$ for every admissible β and $\tilde{\sigma}_p = b$.

If $\Delta^\dagger \in (0, I)$, then Π_p strictly decreases on $[0, \Delta^\dagger]$ and strictly increases on $[\Delta^\dagger, I]$ by Lemma 3, so $\sigma_p^* = b$ whenever $\beta - b \leq \Delta^\dagger$. On $(\Delta^\dagger, I]$, let $h(\Delta) := \Pi_p(\Delta) - \Pi_p(0)$; h is strictly increasing there with $h(\Delta^\dagger) < 0$. If $h(I) \leq 0$, $\sigma_p^* = b$ throughout and $\tilde{\sigma}_p = b + I$; otherwise h has a unique zero $\tilde{\Delta} \in (\Delta^\dagger, I)$, and comparing $\Pi_p(\beta - b)$ to $\Pi_p(0)$ —the two candidates on $[0, \beta - b]$, since a convex function on an interval is maximized at an endpoint—is comparing $h(\beta - b)$ to zero, giving $\sigma_p^* = b$ for $\beta \leq b + \tilde{\Delta}$ and $\sigma_p^* = \beta$ for $\beta > b + \tilde{\Delta}$, so $\tilde{\sigma}_p = b + \tilde{\Delta}$.

In every case $\tilde{\Delta} := \tilde{\sigma}_p - b$ is pinned down by $\Pi_p(\cdot) - \Pi_p(0)$ alone, and by (4), $\Pi_p(\Delta) - \Pi_p(0) = W(I - \Delta) - b - \Delta - (W(I) - b) = W(I - \Delta) - W(I) - \Delta$, in which b cancels: $\tilde{\Delta}$ is the same number for every need b . $\square$

The pre-emption counterfactual of Remark 1

Proof. Drop the bound of Assumption (B) and take $\beta \geq b + I$: the admissible range becomes $[0, I]$, the corner is $\Delta = I$ with $J = 0$, and the threshold equation $J = k \pi^3 f(\pi) / (M(\pi) + \pi^2 f(\pi))$ forces $\pi \rightarrow 0$; in that limit $J/\pi = k \pi^2 f(\pi) / (M(\pi) + \pi^2 f(\pi)) \rightarrow 0$ because $M(0) = \mathbb{E}(\pi) > 0$, hence $\rho_p^* = k - J/\pi(J) \rightarrow k = 1 - \rho_a$ and $W(0) = (1 - \rho_a)\mathbb{E}(\pi)$. With $\sigma_p = b + I$ this gives the stated payoff. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 2

Proof. By Proposition 1, $\pi_{\min} = J/(1 - \rho_a - \rho_p)$ with $\rho_p = \sigma_p/V_p$, so

$$\frac{\partial \pi_{\min}}{\partial V_p} = -\frac{\pi_{\min}^2}{J} \cdot \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} < 0:$$

a more generous pre-seed valuation dilutes the entrepreneur less, leaves more room in the cap table for the seed investor, and therefore lowers the seed threshold. Differentiating Π_p and using $M'(x) = -x f(x)$,

$$\Pi'_p(V_p) = \sigma_p \left(\frac{M'(\pi_{\min}) \partial \pi_{\min} / \partial V_p}{V_p} - \frac{M(\pi_{\min})}{V_p^2} \right) = \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^2} \left(\frac{\sigma_p f(\pi_{\min}) \pi_{\min}^3}{J V_p} - M(\pi_{\min}) \right).$$

Setting $\Pi'_p(V_p) = 0$ yields the stated first-order condition. The derivation holds at a given amount, so Δ and hence J are fixed throughout. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 1

Proof. Substitute $V_p = \sigma_p/\rho_p$ into Proposition 2: the factor σ_p cancels on both sides, leaving $f(\pi) \pi^3 \rho_p = J M(\pi)$. Replacing $\rho_p = 1 - \rho_a - J/\pi$ and rearranging gives the

stated equation. The cancellation of σ_p is what the invariance statement rests on, and it is why the statement is conditional: J survives the cancellation, and J moves with the pre-funded part of the amount. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 4

Proof. Participation requires $\Pi_p(V_p^*) \geq 0$, i.e. $M(\pi_{\min}^*) \geq V_p^*$. Multiplying both sides by $\rho_p^* > 0$ and using $V_p^* \rho_p^* = \sigma_p$ gives the condition; ρ_p^* and $\pi_{\min}^*$ are the constants of Corollary 1. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 5

Proof. Take a constrained pre-seed investor, so that wherever a round occurs Proposition 3 gives $\sigma_p^* = b$, hence $\Delta = 0$ and $J = I$, and recall $b = l - \sigma_a$.

Region (N), $l \leq \sigma_a$. The accelerator's amount already absorbs the shock, so $b \leq 0$: there is no residual need to fund and no claim on which a pre-seed investor could be repaid, and $(\rho_p, \sigma_p) = (0, 0)$. The accelerator's amount is committed before the shock is known and is consumed by the interim stage, so nothing is carried into the round and $J = I$. Proposition 1 with $\rho_p = 0$ then prices the round at $V = I/(1 - \rho_a) = \pi_0$ and finances exactly the projects $\{\pi \geq \pi_0\}$, an event of probability $1 - F(\pi_0)$ conditional on this region.

Region (P), $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$. Here $0 < b \leq \bar{\sigma}_p$, so the participation condition of Proposition 4 holds and a round occurs; the investor advances at least b by Lemma 1 and exactly b by Proposition 3, so $J = I$. The price is the one of Proposition 2 and the threshold it engineers is $\pi_{\min}^* = \pi(I)$, which by Corollary 1 does not depend on b . The capitalization table binds (Proposition 1), so $\rho_p^* = 1 - \rho_a - I/\pi_{\min}^*$, the seed investor funds exactly $\{\pi \geq \pi_{\min}^*\}$, and the conditional probability is $1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)$.

Region (L), $l > \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p$. Now $b > \bar{\sigma}_p = W(I)$, so by (4) the payoff $W(I) - b$ is strictly negative. Since $W(I)$ is the maximum of $\Pi_p + \sigma_p$ over V_p , the bound binds at every price; and advancing less than b is dominated (Lemma 1). No round occurs, the shock is not absorbed, the firm is liquidated before π is revealed, and the conditional probability of a seed round is 0.

Ordering. Both thresholds are the residual investment cost divided by the equity the capitalization table leaves the seed investor, $\pi_0 = I/(1 - \rho_a)$ and $\pi_{\min}^* = I/(1 - \rho_a - \rho_p^*)$, so $\pi_0 < \pi_{\min}^*$ is exactly $\rho_p^* > 0$. That inequality is Lemma 7 applied with $k = 1 - \rho_a$: the root $\pi(I)$ lies strictly above $I/(1 - \rho_a)$, whence $\rho_p^* = 1 - \rho_a - I/\pi(I) > 0$. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 6

Proof. Condition on the three regimes of Proposition 5 and use

$$\mathbb{P}(\text{seed}) = \sum_R \mathbb{P}(R) \mathbb{P}(\text{seed} \mid R), \quad \mathbb{P}(\text{seed} \mid L) = 0.$$

□

Proof of Proposition 7

Proof. Let $\beta > \tilde{\sigma}_p$. Wherever the investor participates, Proposition 3 gives $\sigma_p^* = \beta$, so $\Delta = \beta - b$ and $J(b) = I - \beta + b$, strictly increasing in b and, by (B), strictly positive on the relevant range.

The region. Two conditions are needed. First the shock must be coverable: the amount must reach b by Lemma 1 and cannot exceed β by (B), so $b \leq \beta$. Second the claim must be worth its amount: by (4) the maximized payoff at $\sigma_p = \beta$ is $\Pi_p = W(J(b)) - \beta$, so participation requires $W(J(b)) \geq \beta$. By Lemma 3, $W' = -\Lambda < 0$, and $J(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing, so $b \mapsto W(J(b))$ is strictly decreasing on $[0, \beta]$: the second condition is an upper bound on b . If $W(I) \geq \beta$ it never binds and the region is $b \leq \beta$; otherwise, provided $W(I - \beta) \geq \beta$, strict monotonicity gives a unique root $b^W \in [0, \beta)$ of $W(J(b^W)) = \beta$ and the condition reads $b \leq b^W$; if $W(I - \beta) < \beta$ no shock admits a round. Writing $b^W := \beta$ in the first case, the two conditions combine into $b \leq \bar{b} = \min\{\beta, b^W\}$, that is $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + \bar{b}$.

The threshold. On that region Corollary 1 applies at the residual investment cost $J(b)$ and delivers $\pi(J(b))$, strictly increasing in b because $J(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing and $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing (Lemma 2). The threshold therefore varies across the region where a round occurs: each shock carries its own.

The probability. The region $l \leq \sigma_a$ is unchanged from Proposition 5: no round, $J = I$, threshold π_0 , contributing $G(\sigma_a)(1 - F(\pi_0))$. On $(\sigma_a, \sigma_a + \bar{b}]$ the conditional probability at shock l is $1 - F(\pi(J(l - \sigma_a)))$, and integrating against dG gives the second term; the shock and project distributions no longer separate, so the product of the constrained case becomes an integral. Beyond $\sigma_a + \bar{b}$ the firm is liquidated and the contribution is zero. □

Proof of Proposition 8

Proof. By Corollary 1, raising σ_a leaves π_0 , $\pi_{\min}^*$, ρ_p^* and $\bar{\sigma}_p$ unchanged: they depend on (ρ_a, I, F) only. What changes is the partition of the shock space in Proposition 5: the no-pre-seed region $\{l \leq \sigma_a\}$ expands and the liquidation region $\{l > \sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p\}$

shrinks, both by the same displacement. Differentiating Proposition 6,

$$\frac{\partial \mathbb{P}(\text{seed})}{\partial \sigma_a} = g(\sigma_a)(F(\pi_{\min}^*) - F(\pi_0)) + g(\sigma_a + \bar{\sigma}_p)(1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)) > 0,$$

where the first term is non-negative because $\pi_0 < \pi_{\min}^*$ (Proposition 5) and the second is strictly positive. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 4

Proof. Take the first branch. $V < V_p$ reads $(J + m)/(1 - \rho_a^0 - \sigma_p/V_p) < V_p$, and since the denominator is positive whenever a seed round occurs, this is equivalent to $J + m < (1 - \rho_a^0)V_p - \sigma_p$, that is to $V_p > (J + m + \sigma_p)/(1 - \rho_a^0)$. The second branch is the same computation with m moved into the pre-seed block: $V > V_p$ reads $J > (1 - \rho_a^0)V_p - (\sigma_p + m)$, i.e. $V_p < \widehat{V}_p$. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 5

Proof. In the low-price regime, set $\Pi'_p = 0$: $(\sigma_p + m)f(\pi)\pi^3 = JV_p M(\pi)$. Divide by V_p and use $(\sigma_p + m)/V_p = 1 - \rho_a^0 - J/\pi$:

$$\left(1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{J}{\pi}\right)f(\pi)\pi^3 = JM(\pi) \iff (1 - \rho_a^0)\pi^3 f(\pi) - J\pi^2 f(\pi) - JM(\pi) = 0,$$

which is $\Phi(\pi; J) = 0$. In the high-price regime the same steps with $\sigma_p/V_p = 1 - \rho_a^0 - (J + m)/\pi$ and the factor $(J + m)$ in place of J give $\Phi(\pi; J + m) = 0$. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 6

Proof. Suppose a pre-seed round occurs. If $V_p > \widehat{V}_p$ then $\pi_{\min} = (J + m)/(1 - \rho_a^0 - \sigma_p/V_p) \geq (J + m)/(1 - \rho_a^0) \geq 1$, which is impossible since $\pi_{\min} \leq 1$. If $V_p \leq \widehat{V}_p$ then $\pi_{\min} = J/(1 - \rho_a^0 - (\sigma_p + m)/V_p)$ is decreasing in V_p , hence

$$\pi_{\min} \geq \pi_{\min}(\widehat{V}_p) = \frac{J}{1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{(\sigma_p + m)(1 - \rho_a^0)}{J + m + \sigma_p}} = \frac{J + m + \sigma_p}{1 - \rho_a^0} \geq \frac{J + m}{1 - \rho_a^0} \geq 1,$$

again impossible. Hence $J + m < 1 - \rho_a^0$ whenever a pre-seed round occurs. $\square$

Proof of Lemma 7

Proof. Definition 1 factors as $\Phi(\pi; J) = D(\pi)(\psi(\pi) - J)$, with $D = \pi^2 f + M > 0$ and ψ the map of Lemma 2 read at $k = 1 - \rho_a^0$. That lemma makes ψ a strictly increasing

bijection from $(0, 1)$ onto $(0, k)$, so for $0 < J < 1 - \rho_a^0$ the equation $\psi(\pi) = J$ has exactly one solution π_J , which is therefore the unique root of $\Phi(\cdot; J)$; it lies in $(J/(1 - \rho_a^0), 1)$ because $\psi(\pi) < k\pi$; and Φ , having the sign of $\psi - J$, is negative below it and positive above it. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 9

Proof. Write $k := 1 - \rho_a^0$. The amount σ_p , hence Δ and $J = I - \Delta \in (0, I]$, are held fixed; $\pi_1 = \pi(J)$ and $\pi_2 = \pi(J + m)$ are the roots named after Lemma 7, both well defined under Lemma 6, with $\pi_1 < \pi_2$ because $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing (Lemma 2).

Step 1: choosing a price is choosing a threshold. The round is priced at the marginal project, $V = \pi_{\min}$ (Proposition 1), and the capitalization identity of each conversion regime makes $\pi_{\min}$ continuous and strictly decreasing in V_p :

$$\pi_{\min} = \frac{J}{k - (\sigma_p + m)/V_p} \quad \text{on } V_p \leq \widehat{V}_p, \quad \pi_{\min} = \frac{J + m}{k - \sigma_p/V_p} \quad \text{on } V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p.$$

The two agree at the cutoff of Lemma 4, where both equal $\widehat{V}_p$ itself: substituting $V_p = \widehat{V}_p = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k$ gives $k - (\sigma_p + m)/\widehat{V}_p = kJ/(J + m + \sigma_p)$ and $k - \sigma_p/\widehat{V}_p = k(J + m)/(J + m + \sigma_p)$, so each expression returns $(J + m + \sigma_p)/k$. The investor's problem can therefore be written over $\pi_{\min}$ instead of V_p , with the low-price regime $V_p \leq \widehat{V}_p$ mapping onto $\pi_{\min} \geq \widehat{V}_p$ and the high-price regime onto $\pi_{\min} \leq \widehat{V}_p$.

Step 2: the payoff on each regime. With $\varphi_J(\pi) = (k - J/\pi)M(\pi)$ from (3), read at $k = 1 - \rho_a^0$, substitute the capitalization identity into $\Pi_p = \sigma_p(M(\pi_{\min})/V_p - 1)$. In the low-price regime $(\sigma_p + m)/V_p = k - J/\pi_{\min}$, so $\sigma_p/V_p = \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m}(k - J/\pi_{\min})$; in the high-price regime $\sigma_p/V_p = k - (J + m)/\pi_{\min}$ directly. Hence

$$\Pi_p = \begin{cases} \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m} \varphi_J(\pi_{\min}) - \sigma_p & \text{on } \pi_{\min} \geq \widehat{V}_p \quad (\text{the clause converts at } V_p), \\ \varphi_{J+m}(\pi_{\min}) - \sigma_p & \text{on } \pi_{\min} \leq \widehat{V}_p \quad (\text{the clause converts at } V). \end{cases}$$

The two branches agree at $\pi_{\min} = \widehat{V}_p$, where both equal $\sigma_p(M(\widehat{V}_p)/\widehat{V}_p - 1)$, by the same substitution as in Step 1. Since $\sigma_p/(\sigma_p + m)$ is a constant at a fixed amount, maximizing on the first branch is maximizing φ_J and on the second φ_{J+m} . Differentiating (3) gives $\varphi'_J(\pi) = -\Phi(\pi; J)/\pi^2$, so Lemma 7 makes φ_J strictly increasing below π_1 and strictly decreasing above it, and φ_{J+m} strictly increasing below π_2 and strictly decreasing above it. Each branch therefore has a unique maximizer, the root delivered by Lemma 5 for that branch.

Step 3: which branch wins. By Step 1 the low-price branch is the set $\pi_{\min} \geq \widehat{V}_p$ and the high-price branch the set $\pi_{\min} \leq \widehat{V}_p$, and by (7),

$$\sigma_p \leq T_1 \iff \pi_1 \geq \widehat{V}_p, \quad \sigma_p \leq T_2 \iff \pi_2 \geq \widehat{V}_p,$$

since $\pi_i \geq \widehat{V}_p = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k$ reads $\sigma_p \leq k\pi_i - (J + m)$. Take the three cases in turn, using throughout that the two branches agree at $\widehat{V}_p$ and that φ_J and φ_{J+m} are strictly quasi-concave with peaks at π_1 and π_2 .

If $\sigma_p \leq T_1$, then $\widehat{V}_p \leq \pi_1 < \pi_2$. The low-price branch contains its own peak and attains $\varphi_J(\pi_1)$; the high-price branch lies entirely below π_2 , where φ_{J+m} is strictly increasing, so it is maximized at its endpoint $\widehat{V}_p$, which the low-price branch also attains. The optimum is $\pi_{\min} = \pi_1$.

If $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$, then $\pi_1 < \widehat{V}_p \leq \pi_2$. The low-price branch lies entirely above π_1 , where φ_J is strictly decreasing, and the high-price branch entirely below π_2 , where φ_{J+m} is strictly increasing: both are maximized at the point they share, and the optimum is $\pi_{\min} = \widehat{V}_p$. Then $V = \widehat{V}_p = V_p$ by Step 1.

If $\sigma_p > T_2$, then $\pi_1 < \pi_2 < \widehat{V}_p$. The low-price branch is again maximized at $\widehat{V}_p$, while the high-price branch contains its own peak, so it attains $\varphi_{J+m}(\pi_2) > \varphi_{J+m}(\widehat{V}_p)$, which is the common value at the seam. The optimum is $\pi_{\min} = \pi_2$.

Step 4: the price. In each case the capitalization table binds and $V = \pi_{\min}$ (Proposition 1). In the first, $(\sigma_p + m)/V_p^* = k - J/\pi_1$; in the third, $\sigma_p/V_p^* = k - (J + m)/\pi_2$; in the second, $V_p^* = \widehat{V}_p$ by construction. Inverting gives the three displayed prices. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 10

Proof. Write $k := 1 - \rho_a^0$, and recall $W(J) = \varphi_J(\pi(J))$ from (3) and $M(x) \geq x$ according as $x \leq \bar{x}$, since $M(x) - x$ is strictly decreasing with its zero at $\bar{x}$ (proof of Proposition 3). By Lemma 2, $\pi(J^\dagger) = \bar{x}$ and $\pi(\cdot)$ is strictly increasing, so $\bar{x} \leq \pi_1$, $\pi_1 < \bar{x} \leq \pi_2$ and $\pi_2 < \bar{x}$ are the three cases $J \geq J^\dagger$, $J < J^\dagger \leq J + m$ and $J + m < J^\dagger$.

Participation regime by regime. Take the optimum of Proposition 9 in each of its three ranges and ask when its value is non-negative. Write $A_1 := k - J/\pi_1$ and $A_2 := k - (J + m)/\pi_2$, both positive by Lemma 2, so that $W(J) = A_1 M(\pi_1)$, $W(J + m) = A_2 M(\pi_2)$, and

$$T_1 = A_1 \pi_1 - m, \quad T_2 = A_2 \pi_2. \quad (10)$$

On $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the payoff is $\frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m} W(J) - \sigma_p$, non-negative if and only if $\sigma_p + m \leq W(J)$. On $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$ it is $\sigma_p (M(\widehat{V}_p)/\widehat{V}_p - 1)$, non-negative if and only if $\widehat{V}_p \leq \bar{x}$, that is $\sigma_p \leq k\bar{x} - (J + m)$; and $\widehat{V}_p = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k$ runs over $[\pi_1, \pi_2]$ as σ_p runs over $[T_1, T_2]$. On $\sigma_p > T_2$ it is $W(J + m) - \sigma_p$, non-negative if and only if $\sigma_p \leq W(J + m)$.

The three cases. Suppose $\bar{x} \leq \pi_1$. Then $M(\pi_1) \leq \pi_1$, so by (10) the first cap $W(J) - m = A_1 M(\pi_1) - m$ is at most $A_1 \pi_1 - m = T_1$: the first range is cut short by participation. The second contributes nothing, since $\widehat{V}_p \geq \pi_1 \geq \bar{x}$ there; and neither does the third, since $\pi_2 > \pi_1 \geq \bar{x}$ gives $M(\pi_2) < \pi_2$ and hence $W(J + m) < T_2$ by (10). The cap is $W(J) - m$ and only the first regime is reached.

Suppose $\pi_1 < \bar{x} \leq \pi_2$. Now $M(\pi_1) > \pi_1$ gives $W(J) - m > T_1$, so every amount in the first range participates. In the second, participation holds up to $k\bar{x} - (J + m)$, which lies in $(T_1, T_2]$ because $\pi_1 < \bar{x} \leq \pi_2$. The third is again empty, since $M(\pi_2) \leq \pi_2$. The cap is $k\bar{x} - (J + m)$ and the first two regimes are reached.

Suppose $\pi_2 < \bar{x}$. The first range participates throughout as before; so does the second, since $\hat{V}_p \leq \pi_2 < \bar{x}$ on it; and in the third, participation holds up to $W(J + m) = A_2 M(\pi_2) > A_2 \pi_2 = T_2$. The cap is $W(J + m)$ and all three regimes are reached.

In each case the amounts a participating investor advances form the single interval $[0, \bar{\sigma}_p^m]$ claimed. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 2

Proof. If $J \geq J^\dagger$ then $\bar{x} \leq \pi_1$, and by Proposition 10 every participating amount satisfies $\sigma_p \leq W(J) - m \leq T_1$: the first regime of Proposition 9 is played, with $V_p^* = (\sigma_p + m)/(k - J/\pi_1)$ and $\pi_{\min}^* = \pi_1$. That threshold is the root of $\Phi(\cdot; J)$, which is the equation of Corollary 1 with ρ_a replaced by ρ_a^0 , and the seed investor holds $J/V = J/\pi_1$, its benchmark stake. For the strict inequality,

$$V_p^* < V = \pi_1 \iff \sigma_p + m < k\pi_1 - J = A_1\pi_1 \iff \sigma_p < T_1,$$

and participation gives $\sigma_p + m \leq A_1 M(\pi_1)$ with $M(\pi_1) \leq \pi_1$, the second inequality strict unless $\pi_1 = \bar{x}$. Finally the clause converts at V_p^* , so the accelerator holds $\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + m/V_p^*$ and the pre-seed investor holds

$$\rho_p^* = \frac{\sigma_p}{V_p^*} = \left(1 - \rho_a^0 - \frac{J}{\pi_1}\right) - \frac{m}{V_p^*},$$

its benchmark share net of the accelerator's gain. $\square$

Proof of Remark 2

Proof. A best-price claim converts at $\sigma_p / \min(V, V_p)$, so it differs from the fixed-base claim priced at V_p only in states where $V < V_p$. On $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ there are none: by Proposition 11(i) the cap binds and the claim converts at $V_p^* = (\sigma_p + m)/(k - J/\pi_1)$, which satisfies $V_p^* \leq V = \pi_1$ because $\sigma_p + m \leq k\pi_1 - J$ is $\sigma_p \leq T_1$. Hence $\min(V, V_p^*) = V_p^*$: the two instruments induce the same conversion, the same capitalization table and the same payoff, so the investor's problem—and therefore its optimal price—is unchanged. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 11

Proof. Write $k := 1 - \rho_a^0$. Both claims now convert at $\min(V, V_p)$, so the two branches of Step 1 in the proof of Proposition 9 change in one place. On $V_p \leq \widehat{V}_p$ the minimum is V_p for both, the capitalization table is $\rho_a^0 + (\sigma_p + m)/V_p + J/V = 1$ as before, and the investor's problem is the low-price branch unchanged; by Step 3 its optimum is π_1 when $\sigma_p \leq T_1$, and the endpoint $\widehat{V}_p$ otherwise.

On $V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p$ the minimum is V for both, so the table reads $\rho_a^0 + (\sigma_p + m)/V + J/V = 1$, that is $V = (J + m + \sigma_p)/k = \widehat{V}_p$, independently of V_p . Price and threshold are then constants and $\Pi_p = \sigma_p(M(\widehat{V}_p)/\widehat{V}_p - 1)$ for every $V_p \geq \widehat{V}_p$: the whole range is optimal and delivers one payoff, the value the low-price branch attains at its endpoint. Hence for $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the optimum is π_1 , and for $\sigma_p > T_1$ it is $\widehat{V}_p$. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 12

Proof. At any amount, the fixed-base claim attains the larger of the two branch maxima of Proposition 9, while by Proposition 11 the best-price claim attains the larger of the low-price maximum and the plateau value $\sigma_p(M(\widehat{V}_p)/\widehat{V}_p - 1)$, which is the value both branches take at $\widehat{V}_p$. Since the high-price branch is maximized at π_2 and $\varphi_{J+m}(\pi_2) \geq \varphi_{J+m}(\widehat{V}_p)$, the fixed-base claim is worth weakly more; and the inequality is strict exactly when $\pi_2 < \widehat{V}_p$, that is when $\sigma_p > T_2$.

For the last statement, suppose $\pi_1 \geq \bar{x}$. By Proposition 10 no participating amount exceeds T_1 , a fortiori none exceeds T_2 , so a fixed-base holder advancing one would earn a strictly negative payoff and not propose; both claims are then worth zero. A strict gap at an amount the investor would actually advance therefore requires $\pi_1 < \bar{x}$. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 13

Proof. Coincidence on $\sigma_p \leq T_2$. On $\sigma_p \leq T_1$ the two instruments induce the same conversion and the same capitalization table (Remark 2). On $T_1 < \sigma_p \leq T_2$, Proposition 9(ii) gives $V^* = \widehat{V}_p$ with $\rho_a^* = \rho_a^0 + km/(J + m + \sigma_p) = \rho_a^0 + m/\widehat{V}_p$, $\rho_p^* = \sigma_p/\widehat{V}_p$ and $\rho_s^* = J/\widehat{V}_p$; by Proposition 11(ii) the best-price claim also delivers $V^* = \widehat{V}_p$ with both claims converting at the round, hence the same three stakes. Equal stakes, equal amounts and one threshold give equal payoffs.

Strict ranking on $\sigma_p > T_2$. There $V^* = \pi_2$ under the fixed-base claim (Proposition 9(iii)) and $V^* = \widehat{V}_p$ under the best-price claim (Proposition 11(ii)), with $k\widehat{V}_p = J + m + \sigma_p > k\pi_2$, that is $\widehat{V}_p > \pi_2$. In both the accelerator's claim converts at the round price, so the capitalization table is $\rho_a^0 + m/V^*$, $k - (J + m)/V^*$

and J/V^* , and

$$\Pi_p = \varphi_{J+m}(V^*) - \sigma_p, \quad \Pi_a = \rho_a^0 M(V^*) + m \frac{M(V^*)}{V^*} - \sigma_a - m, \quad \Pi_s = J S(V^*),$$

each a function of V^* alone at fixed (σ_p, J) . Now φ_{J+m} is maximized at $\pi(J+m) = \pi_2$ and strictly decreasing above it (Lemma 2(ii)); $M' = -Vf < 0$; $(M(V)/V)' = -(V^2 f(V) + M(V))/V^2 < 0$; and $S' = -M/V^2 < 0$ by the proof of Proposition 18. Evaluating at $\hat{V}_p > \pi_2$ therefore lowers all three strictly. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 3

Proof. By Proposition 3 the pivot $\tilde{\Delta}$ is the zero of $h(\Delta) := \Pi_p(\Delta) - \Pi_p(0)$ on the increasing branch, and the same construction applies under the clause to $h^m(\Delta) := \Pi_p^m(\Delta) - \Pi_p^m(0)$. By Proposition 14, $\partial \Pi_p^m / \partial \Delta \geq \partial \Pi_p / \partial \Delta$ at every Δ , with strict inequality wherever $V_p^* < V$. Integrating from 0,

$$h^m(\Delta) = \int_0^\Delta \frac{\partial \Pi_p^m}{\partial x} dx \geq \int_0^\Delta \frac{\partial \Pi_p}{\partial x} dx = h(\Delta) \quad \text{for every } \Delta > 0.$$

Both functions are strictly increasing on that branch (Lemma 3), so the zero of the larger one comes first: $\tilde{\Delta}^m \leq \tilde{\Delta}$, strictly when the inequality between the integrands is strict on a set of positive measure. Since $\sigma_p^* = \beta$ exactly when $\beta > b + \tilde{\Delta}$, lowering the pivot enlarges the set of budgets on which the investor pre-funds. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 14

Proof. In regime (i) the pre-seed investor and the MFN SAFE convert on the same base, so the investor holds the fraction $\sigma_p/(\sigma_p + m)$ of a total claim whose value is $W(J)$, and $\Pi_p = \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m} W(J) - \sigma_p$ with $\sigma_p = b + \Delta$ and $J = I - \Delta$. Differentiating, and using $W'(J) = -\Lambda(J)$ from Lemma 3,

$$\frac{\partial \Pi_p}{\partial \Delta} = \frac{m}{(\sigma_p + m)^2} W(J) + \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m} \Lambda(J) - 1.$$

Subtracting $\Lambda(J) - 1$ leaves $\frac{m}{(\sigma_p + m)^2} [W(J) - (\sigma_p + m)\Lambda(J)]$. Substituting $W(J) = \rho_p^{\text{tot}} M(\pi_1)$ with $\rho_p^{\text{tot}} = (\sigma_p + m)/V_p^*$ and $\Lambda(J) = M(\pi_1)/\pi_1$ collapses the bracket to $(\sigma_p + m)M(\pi_1)[1/V_p^* - 1/\pi_1]$, which is non-negative because the first regime carries $V_p^* \leq V = \pi_1$ by Proposition 9, and strictly positive when that inequality is strict. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 15

Proof. The two prices generate the table. In regime (i), $V_p^* < V = \pi_1$, so $P^* = V_p^* = (\sigma_p + m)/(k - J/\pi_1)$ and $m/P^* = (k - J/\pi_1)m/(\sigma_p + m)$, which is the accelerator's

entry; the seed entry is $J/\pi_1 = J/V^*$. In regime (ii) the two prices coincide at $\widehat{V}_p$ and the entries are $m/\widehat{V}_p$ and $J/\widehat{V}_p$. In regime (iii), $V_p^* > V = \pi_2$, so $P^* = \pi_2$ and the entries are m/π_2 and J/π_2 . In each case the three stakes of Proposition 9 sum to k , which gives the third expression in (8), and the fourth is the definition of the pre-seed price. Setting $m = 0$ leaves $\rho_p = k - J/\pi_1$ and $V_p = \sigma_p/\rho_p$, the benchmark column.

Continuity and monotonicity. By (7), $\sigma_p = T_1$ gives $\widehat{V}_p = (J + m + T_1)/k = \pi_1$, and $k - J/\pi_1 = (k\pi_1 - J)/\pi_1 = (T_1 + m)/\pi_1$, so the regime (i) price evaluated at T_1 is $(T_1 + m)/((T_1 + m)/\pi_1) = \pi_1$ as well: both prices are continuous at T_1 and equal π_1 there. Likewise $\sigma_p = T_2$ gives $\widehat{V}_p = \pi_2$ and $k - (J + m)/\pi_2 = T_2/\pi_2$, so the regime (iii) price evaluated at T_2 is π_2 : both are continuous at T_2 and equal π_2 . Between the joins, P^* is affine and strictly increasing in σ_p on (i) and on (ii) and constant on (iii), while V^* is constant at π_1 on (i), equal to $\widehat{V}_p$ and strictly increasing on (ii), and constant at π_2 on (iii); $\pi_1 < \pi_2$ by Lemma 2. Continuity of the entries follows from (8).

Across the regimes. m/P^* and J/V^* are non-increasing in σ_p by the previous step, so ρ_a^* and ρ_s^* fall and $\rho_p^* = k - J/V^* - m/P^*$ rises. The pre-seed price σ_p/ρ_p^* is affine and strictly increasing in σ_p within each regime and continuous at the joins, hence increasing throughout. $V^* = \pi_{\min}^*$ rises by the previous step and $1 - F$ is decreasing.

Against the benchmark. In regime (i), $\rho_p^* = \rho_p^{\text{bench}} \sigma_p/(\sigma_p + m) < \rho_p^{\text{bench}}$. On (ii), $\widehat{V}_p \leq \pi_2$ gives $\rho_p^* = k - (J + m)/\widehat{V}_p \leq k - (J + m)/\pi_2$, the regime (iii) value, so it suffices to compare that value with the benchmark: $k - (J + m)/\pi(J + m) < k - J/\pi(J)$ holds if and only if $J \mapsto J/\pi(J)$ is strictly increasing. Writing $J = \psi(\pi)$ with $\pi = \pi(J)$ increasing (Lemma 2), $J/\pi(J) = \psi(\pi)/\pi = k\pi^2 f/(\pi^2 f + M)$, which increases in π if and only if $M/(\pi^2 f)$ decreases. Using $M' = -\pi f$, that derivative has the sign of $-\left[\pi^2 f^2 + M(2f + \pi f')\right]$, so the claim is

$$\pi^2 f(\pi) + M(\pi)(2 - c\pi) > 0, \quad c := -f'(\pi)/f(\pi),$$

immediate when $c \leq 2/\pi$ since $f > 0$. When $c > 2/\pi$ the second term is negative, and the log-concavity bound $M(\pi) \leq f(\pi)(c\pi + 1)/c^2$ established in the proof of Lemma 2 can only lower the left-hand side:

$$\pi^2 f + M(2 - c\pi) \geq \frac{f}{c^2} \left(c^2 \pi^2 + (c\pi + 1)(2 - c\pi) \right) = \frac{f}{c^2} (c\pi + 2) > 0.$$

Hence $\rho_p^* < \rho_p^{\text{bench}}$ in all three regimes, and $V_p^* = \sigma_p/\rho_p^* > \sigma_p/\rho_p^{\text{bench}}$ reverses the inequality. For the remaining rows, $V^* = \pi_1$ in regime (i) leaves ρ_s^* , the round price and $1 - F(\pi_{\min}^*)$ at their benchmark values, while $V^* > \pi_1$ strictly on (ii) and (iii)—by $\sigma_p > T_1$ and $\pi_1 < \pi_2$ respectively—raises the threshold, lowers J/V^* and lowers $1 - F(V^*)$. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 16

Proof. Write $b^b = l - \sigma_a$ and $b^m = b^b - m$ for the residual needs the two contracts leave, σ_p^b, σ_p^m for the equilibrium amounts, $J = I - (\sigma_p - b)$ in each game, and $\pi^b = \pi(J^b)$. With $\rho_a^0 = \rho_a$, (1) gives

$$\Pi_a^m - \Pi_a^b = \rho_a [M(V^*) - M(\pi^b)] + m \left[\frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} - 1 \right]. \quad (11)$$

Step 1: the second bracket. $P^* = \min(V^*, V_p^*) \leq V_p^*$, and $\rho_p^* = \sigma_p^*/V_p^*$ by (8), so

$$\frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} \geq \frac{M(V^*)}{V_p^*} = \frac{\rho_p^* M(V^*)}{\sigma_p^*} = 1 + \frac{\Pi_p^*}{\sigma_p^*} \geq 1,$$

the last inequality because the pre-seed investor advances σ_p^* only if $\Pi_p^* \geq 0$, and strict whenever $\Pi_p^* > 0$, that is at every $\sigma_p^* < \bar{\sigma}_p^m$ (Proposition 10). Since the first bracket of (11) is non-negative by Steps 2 and 3, this makes $\Pi_a^m > \Pi_a^b$ below the cap. At the cap the bracket vanishes only if $P^* = V_p^*$, which fails on $\sigma_p^* > T_2$, and the first bracket vanishes only if $V^* = \pi^b$, which by Step 3 requires both investors to advance the shock and no more; equality therefore also requires $\bar{\sigma}_p^m \leq T_1$.

Step 2: the amounts. Since $b^m = b^b - m$,

$$J^m + m - J^b = \sigma_p^b - \sigma_p^m.$$

Both amounts are corners, $\sigma_p \in \{b, \beta\}$ (Proposition 3). If $\sigma_p^b = \beta$ then $\beta > b^b + \tilde{\Delta} = b^m + m + \tilde{\Delta} \geq b^m + \tilde{\Delta}^m + m$ by Corollary 3, so $\beta > \tilde{\sigma}_p^m$ and $\sigma_p^m = \beta$ as well. If $\sigma_p^b = b^b$ and $\sigma_p^m = \beta$, then $\beta \geq b^b = \sigma_p^b$, the benchmark investor's own budget constraint. In either case $\sigma_p^m \geq \sigma_p^b$, hence $J^m + m \leq J^b$; and since $V^* \leq \pi(J^m + m)$ in all three regimes (Proposition 9, where V^* is π_1 , $\hat{V}_p \leq \pi_2$ or π_2) and $\pi(\cdot)$ is increasing (Lemma 2(iii)), $V^* \leq \pi^b$. The first bracket of (11) is then non-negative.

Step 3: the remaining case. Step 2 leaves only $\sigma_p^m = b^m$ with $\sigma_p^b = b^b$, where $J^m = J^b = I$. Suppose $\sigma_p^m > T_1$ there. Because the benchmark investor participates, $\beta \geq b^b = b^m + m$, so $\Delta = m$ is available under the clause; it sets $\sigma_p = b^b$ and $J = I - m$. Now $\sigma_p^m > T_1$ reads $b^b + I > k\pi(I)$, which is exactly $\sigma_p > k\pi(I) - I$, the threshold T_2 at that deviation, so Proposition 9(iii) applies there and $\Pi_p^m(m) = W(I) - b^b$. At $\Delta = 0$, parts (ii)–(iii) of the same proposition give $\rho_p^* = k - (I + m)/V^*$ and hence $\Pi_p^m(0) = \varphi_{I+m}(V^*) - b^b + m$. By Lemma 2(ii),

$$W(I) = \varphi_I(\pi(I)) \geq \varphi_I(V^*) = \varphi_{I+m}(V^*) + m \frac{M(V^*)}{V^*},$$

so that

$$\Pi_p^m(m) - \Pi_p^m(0) \geq m \left[\frac{M(V^*)}{V^*} - 1 \right].$$

Regimes (ii) and (iii) are reached only where $V^* \leq \bar{x}$: by Proposition 10, $\pi_1 \geq \bar{x}$ caps the amount at T_1 , while $\pi_1 < \bar{x} \leq \pi_2$ caps it at $k\bar{x} - (J + m)$, that is at $\hat{V}_p \leq \bar{x}$, and $\pi_2 < \bar{x}$ leaves $V^* \leq \pi_2 < \bar{x}$. Since $M - \text{id}$ is strictly decreasing and vanishes at $\bar{x}$, $V^* \leq \bar{x}$ gives $M(V^*) \geq V^*$ and the deviation is weakly profitable. It is strictly profitable unless $V^* = \bar{x}$, where $\Pi_p^m(0) = \sigma_p^m(M(\bar{x})/\bar{x} - 1) = 0$ while $\Pi_p^m(m) = W(I) - b^b > 0$ at every shock strictly inside the benchmark's participation region. Either way $\Delta = 0$ is not optimal, a contradiction. Hence $\sigma_p^m \leq T_1$, so $V^* = \pi(I) = \pi^b$ and the first bracket of (11) vanishes. Step 1 closes the proof. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 17

Proof. Step 1: a bound at a given amount and residual cost. For every (σ_p, J) ,

$$\Pi_p^m(\sigma_p, J) \leq W(J + m) - \sigma_p, \quad (12)$$

with equality if and only if $\sigma_p \geq T_2$. In regimes (ii) and (iii) $\rho_p^* = k - (J + m)/V^*$, so $\Pi_p^m = \varphi_{J+m}(V^*) - \sigma_p$, which is at most $W(J + m) - \sigma_p$ by Lemma 2(ii), with equality exactly at $V^* = \pi_2$, that is $\sigma_p \geq T_2$. In regime (i), $\Pi_p^m = \frac{\sigma_p}{\sigma_p + m}W(J) - \sigma_p$, and $\sigma_p \leq T_1 = k\pi_1 - (J + m)$ gives

$$\sigma_p \frac{M(\pi_1)}{\pi_1} \leq \left(k - \frac{J + m}{\pi_1}\right)M(\pi_1) = \varphi_{J+m}(\pi_1) \leq W(J + m),$$

while $W(J) - W(J + m) = \int_J^{J+m} \Lambda < m \Lambda(J) = m M(\pi_1)/\pi_1$ by Lemma 3, Λ being strictly decreasing. Multiplying the second by σ_p and inserting the first, $\sigma_p W(J) < (\sigma_p + m)W(J + m)$, which is (12) strictly.

Step 2: a bound at a common Δ . At a common Δ the two games face the same J and amounts differing by m , $\sigma_p^m = \sigma_p^b - m$. Using $\rho_p^* = k - J/V^* - m/P^*$ from (8),

$$\varphi_J(V^*) = \rho_p^* M(V^*) + m \frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} = \Pi_p^m(\Delta) + \sigma_p^b + m \left[\frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} - 1 \right],$$

so $\Pi_p^b(\Delta) = W(J) - \sigma_p^b \geq \varphi_J(V^*) - \sigma_p^b$ yields

$$\Pi_p^b(\Delta) - \Pi_p^m(\Delta) \geq m \left[\frac{M(V^*)}{P^*} - 1 \right] \geq 0$$

by Step 1 of the proof of Proposition 16.

Step 3: the corners. The clause's amount is a corner, $\Delta^m \in \{0, \beta - b^m\}$. If $\Delta^m = \beta - b^m$ then $\sigma_p^m = \beta$ and $J^m = I - \beta + b^m$, and the pair $(\beta, J^m + m)$ is what the benchmark faces at $\Delta = \beta - b^b$, a feasible choice for it; by (12), $\Pi_p^m \leq W(J^m + m) - \beta = \Pi_p^b(\beta - b^b) \leq \Pi_p^b$. If $\Delta^m = 0$ then, by Step 2 of the proof of Proposition 16, the benchmark investor also advances b^b , so $\Delta = 0$ is its own optimum and Step 2 above applies.

Equality. At $\Delta^m = 0$ both games are in regime (i) at $J = I$ (Step 3 of the proof of Proposition 16) and $\sigma_p^m + m = \sigma_p^b$, so $\Pi_p^m = (1 - m/\sigma_p^b)\Pi_p^b$ and the gap is $(m/\sigma_p^b)\Pi_p^b$, which vanishes only where the benchmark investor is indifferent to participating. At $\Delta^m = \beta - b^m$ the chain of Step 3 is tight only if (12) holds with equality, that is $\sigma_p^* > T_2$, and if the benchmark investor also advances β . $\square$

Proof of Proposition 18

Proof. The seed investor contributes J against J/V^* of the company in the states where the round occurs, so $\Pi_s = (J/V^*)M(V^*) - J(1 - F(V^*)) = JS(V^*)$, and with $M' = -Vf$,

$$S'(V) = \frac{M'(V)V - M(V)}{V^2} + f(V) = -f(V) - \frac{M(V)}{V^2} + f(V) = -\frac{M(V)}{V^2} < 0.$$

The displayed decomposition is an identity. Its signs follow from the proof of Proposition 16: $S(V^*) \geq 0$ because the seed investor proposes (Proposition 1); Step 2 gives $J^m + m \leq J^b$ and $V^* \leq \pi^b$, so the first term is non-positive and, S being decreasing, the second is non-negative. Where the pre-seed investor advances the shock and no more, Step 3 gives $J^m = J^b = I$ and $V^* = \pi(I) = \pi^b$ and both vanish. Where $\sigma_p^* > T_2$ at a budget that binds in both games, $\sigma_p^m = \sigma_p^b = \beta$ gives $J^m = J^b - m$ and $V^* = \pi(J^m + m) = \pi^b$, so the second term vanishes and the first is $-mS(\pi^b)$. $\square$

Proof of Corollary 4

Proof. By Step 3 of the proof of Proposition 16 that case has $J^m = J^b = I$, $\sigma_p^m \leq T_1$ and $V^* = \pi(I) = \pi^b$, so $\Pi_s^m = IS(\pi(I)) = \Pi_s^b$. In regime (i) $V_p^* = (\sigma_p^m + m)/(k - I/\pi_1)$ with $\pi_1 = \pi(I)$, and $\sigma_p^m + m = b^b = \sigma_p^b$, so $M(\pi_1)/V_p^* = W(I)/\sigma_p^b$ and (11) reduces to

$$\Pi_a^m - \Pi_a^b = m \left[\frac{W(I)}{\sigma_p^b} - 1 \right] = \frac{m}{\sigma_p^b} \Pi_p^b,$$

using $\Pi_p^b = W(I) - \sigma_p^b$. The equality with $-(\Pi_p^m - \Pi_p^b)$ is the gap computed at the end of the proof of Proposition 17. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 19

Proof. Part (a). On $l \leq \sigma_a$ the accelerator's cash covers the shock in both games, no pre-seed investor sits on the table, and the seed investor advances $J = I$. At the threshold its offer leaves the entrepreneur nothing, so the table saturates. In the benchmark that reads $\rho_a + I/\pi_0 = 1$, which is Proposition 5(N). Under the clause the accelerator also holds the tranche, which has no pre-seed price to claim and therefore

converts at the round, so the same condition reads $\rho_a + m/\pi_0^m + I/\pi_0^m = 1$, that is $\pi_0^m = (I + m)/(1 - \rho_a) = (1 + m/I)\pi_0$. The ratio is independent of l and $1 - F$ is decreasing.

Part (b). Step 2 of the proof of Proposition 16 gives $\sigma_p^m \geq \sigma_p^b$ in every configuration but one, hence $J^m + m \leq J^b$; since $V^* \leq \pi(J^m + m)$ in all three regimes (Proposition 9) and $\pi(\cdot)$ is increasing (Lemma 2(iii)), $V^* \leq \pi(J^b)$. Step 3 settles the excluded configuration—both investors advancing the shock and no more—by showing the amount is then below T_1 , so that regime (i) applies with $J^m = J^b = I$ and $V^* = \pi(I) = \pi(J^b)$. For the equality condition, $\pi(J^m + m) = \pi(J^b)$ requires $\sigma_p^m = \sigma_p^b$, and $V^* = \pi(J^m + m)$ requires regime (iii), where $V^* = \pi_2$; in regimes (i) and (ii) $V^* < \pi_2$ strictly. Any other configuration makes one of the two inequalities strict.

Part (c). On $\sigma_a < l \leq \sigma_a + m$ the reformed contribution $\sigma_a + m$ covers the shock on its own, so $\sigma_p^m = 0$, $J^m = I$, and the threshold is the π_0^m of part (a). The benchmark is in region (P) of Proposition 5 at $J^b = I - (\sigma_p^b - b^b)$, with threshold $\pi(J^b)$. If $\sigma_p^b = b^b$ then $J^b = I$, and $\pi_0^m < \pi(I)$ reads $I + m < (1 - \rho_a)\pi(I)$, which is $T_1 > 0$ evaluated at $J = I$. If the investor pre-funds, $J^b = I - \beta + b^b$ falls with the budget and $\pi(J^b) < \pi_0^m$ as soon as $J^b < J_0^m$, again because $\pi(\cdot)$ is increasing. Both configurations are compatible with (A1) and (B). $\square$

B What reproduces the post-reform period

Section 5.4 shows that the reform accounts for about one per cent of the movement in financing outcomes across January 2022. This appendix asks the complementary question: holding the estimated contract structure fixed, what displacement of the primitives reproduces the post-reform cohorts? The exercise is out-of-sample discipline on the model rather than a second application of it. A structure estimated to evaluate a clause is asked to absorb a shock it was not built for, using the same equilibrium and the same nine post-reform moments, and the question is whether it can do so at all.

Table 9 reports nested worlds. In each, the post-reform contract is imposed and a subset of primitives is freed.

The contract alone cannot reproduce the post-reform period, which is Section 5.4 restated. Neither can quality alone, nor the cost of the priced round alone. Only the pair (F, G) passes, and the two are separately necessary for a reason the model makes precise. Freeing F alone fails on the median interim check at -9.8 standard errors: because F does not touch the distribution of amounts, the only way it can bring graduation down by the observed factor is to make projects so poor that rounds shrink with them, giving a simulated median check of \$1.38M against \$2.60M observed. G is required to hold the amounts up while graduation collapses.

	What is freed	Param.	Criterion	d.f.	p
(0)	Nothing—the contract alone	0	1107.5	9	10^{-232}
(a)	F : the distribution of quality	2	208.5	7	10^{-41}
(c)	I : the cost of the priced round	2	47.4	7	$5 \cdot 10^{-8}$
(b)	G : the distribution of shocks	3	17.5	6	0.0075
(d)	F and G jointly	5	5.47	4	0.24

Table 9: Nested worlds fitted to the nine post-reform Y Combinator moments, with the post-reform contract imposed throughout. Only (d) is not rejected, and both of its components are necessary: adding F to G lowers the criterion from 17.5 to 5.47, a drop of 12.1 on two degrees of freedom, $p = 0.002$. The worst single moment gap under (d) is 1.43 standard errors.

What the accepted world requires is $\mathbb{E}(\pi)$ lower by 20.7% with $\sigma(\pi)$ higher by 22.5%—a longer lower tail with an unchanged upper one—together with a median shock higher by 149% and p_0 lower by 65%.

A rejected alternative. A venture correction is a fall in the value of exits, so the natural single-parameter story is a change in the scale X . It is rejected. Freeing X alone gives a criterion of 324.4 on eight degrees of freedom with X falling 37%, and when all primitives are free X *rises* by 30%. The reason is structural: X enters only through I/X , b/X and $V = \pi X$, so it moves thresholds and amounts together, while the post-reform period has graduation collapsing by a factor of 4.4 with amounts holding (interim median \$2.50M to \$2.60M, priced median \$13.1M to \$15.0M).

Corroboration, and its limits. The two displacements are not equally well supported outside the estimation, and the asymmetry should be stated rather than left for a reader to find.

The shock channel G is corroborated out of sample. Techstars, which changed nothing, loses 13.1 points of interim-round probability and 4.5 points of graduation over the same window, against zero predicted by the model for an accelerator whose contract is unchanged. That is a market-wide movement measured outside Y Combinator and outside the model.

The quality channel F is corroborated inside the pre-reform sample and contradicted outside it. Within pre-reform Y Combinator cohorts, where no clause is present, the size of the batch predicts graduation: a correlation of -0.73 across cohorts, and at the company level, clustering on cohort, -15.5 points per hundred additional companies ($t = -3.49$, $p = 0.017$). Y Combinator grew from 424 companies in 2020 to 695 in 2021, a year before the clause, which the relation maps to -8.8 points against -15.6 observed. But the same test on pre-reform Techstars cohorts runs the other

way—batch sizes of 79, 85, 136, 162 against graduation rates of 0.051, 0.012, 0.110, 0.111, a correlation of +0.89. “Larger batch, weaker cohort” is therefore not a general regularity; it is a feature of Y Combinator in this window. Post-reform the relation is absent altogether ($p = 0.70$), which is consistent with the floor that graduation reaches.

The conclusion this appendix supports is accordingly narrow and should be stated in the terms that are measured rather than in the terms one might infer. The post-reform decline is entirely reproduced by a displacement of the quality distribution together with a displacement of the distribution of liquidity needs, *neither of which is attributable to the change of terms*. What produced each displacement is a separate question: batch expansion and a venture correction are the candidates, the second is corroborated outside the sample and the first is not, and the model has nothing to say about either.